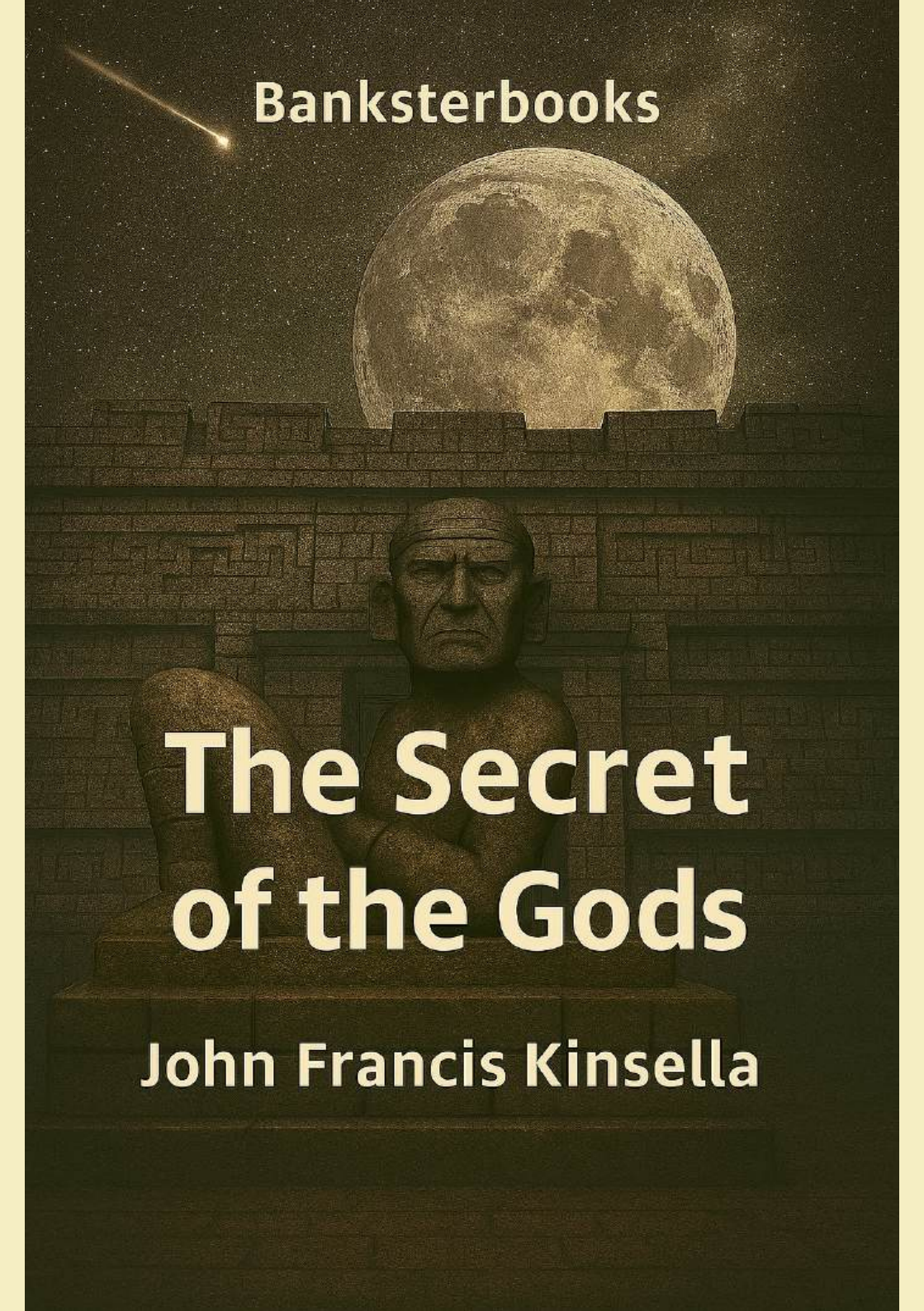




Banksterbooks

The Secret of the Gods

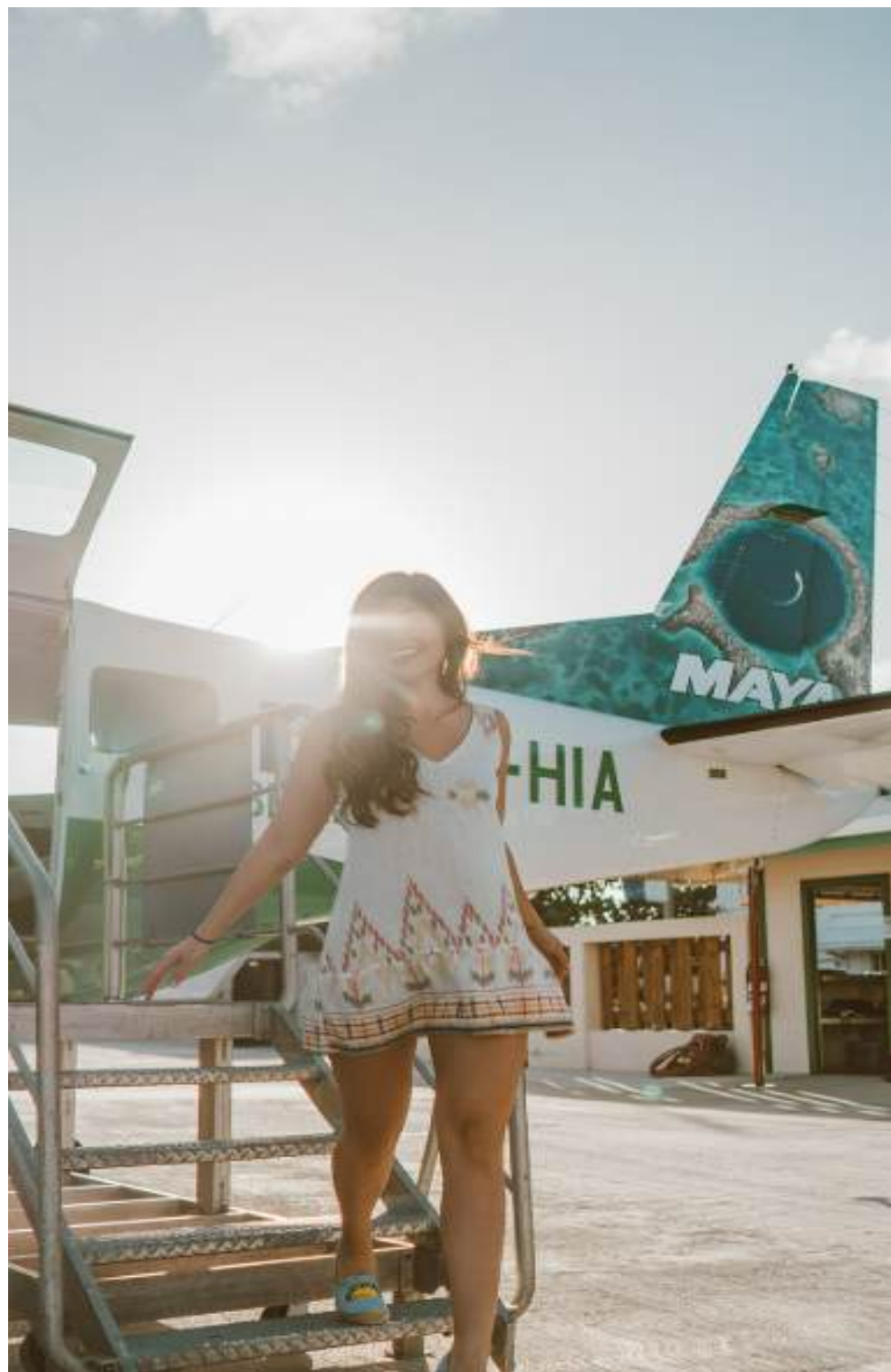
John Francis Kinsella

Based on the novel by
John Francis Kinsella

Published by
Banksterbooks

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Viva España



CHAPTER ONE

Spain

↑ Llegadas
Arrivals

Barry Simmonds, 'Simmo' to his friends, arrived at Madrid's Barajas International Airport on an early morning flight from Geneva.

Spain's frontiers had just opened after the Covid lockdown. But he wasn't worried about the virus...

It was June 24, and he was more concerned about getting through formalities than anything else.

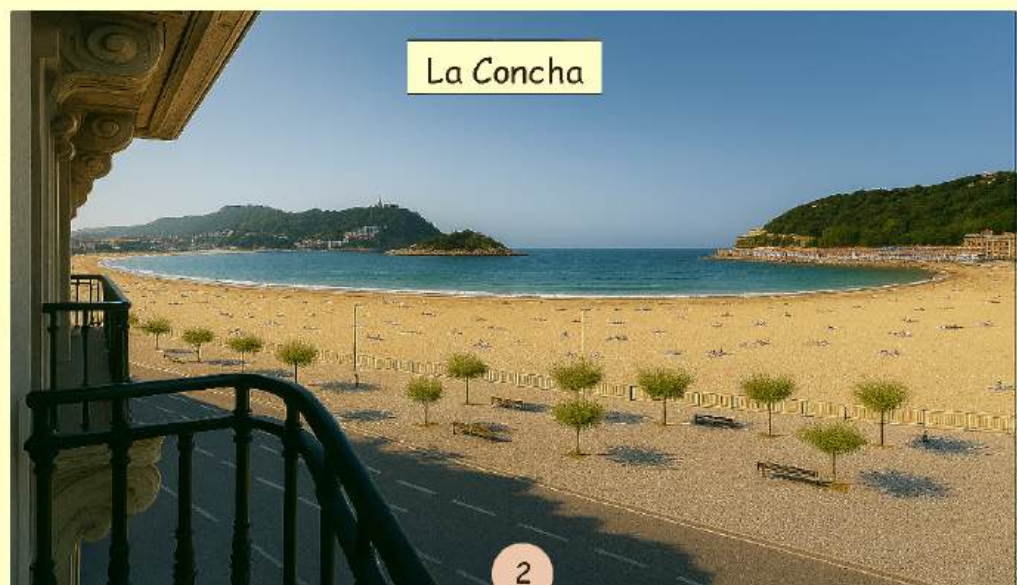
His plan was to rent a car and head north to the city of San Sebastian, 460 kilometres to the north-west, in Spain's Basque Country.



Relieved to have passed the formalities unremarked Simmo, headed in the direction of the car rental desks.



Once in San Sebastian, he made his way along Easo Kalea towards Hotel de Londres y Inglaterra.

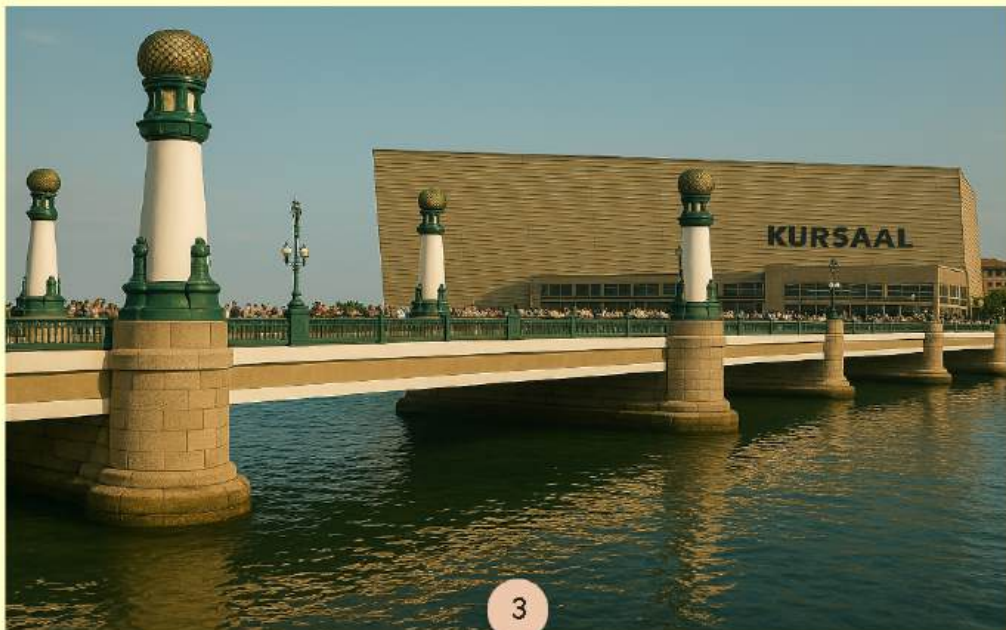


La Concha

After checking in at the hotel, Simmo called Scott Fitznorman, a Parisian antiques dealer, then set off for the Kursaal where they had agreed to meet.



It was an easy 15 minute walk away over the Zurriola Bridge.





FERIA DE ANTIGÜEDADES Y ARTES ÈTNICAS



KURSAAL SAN SEBASTIÁN 20-27 JUNIO 2021





Barry preferred to talk
outside of the fair and
Scott suggested a quiet bar
he knew in the Old Town.





It was a quiet moment and they chose a table away from the bar.



Scott was astonished. It was an Aztec codex dating from the late 16th century ... if it was genuine. In any case it look like the real thing. Authentic. The question was where did it come from and he asked Barry to tell him its story, how he acquired it, its previous owners.



George Wallace, a business associate of Simmonds, had been found floating dead in his pool near Belize City. An accident according to the police. Simmonds was the legal executor of the defunct's estate and was contacted by the manager of a local bank in Belize who informed him of a safe deposit box in Wallace's name for which the rental was overdue..



At first glance there were the usual things in the safebox: cash, small gold bars and passports.

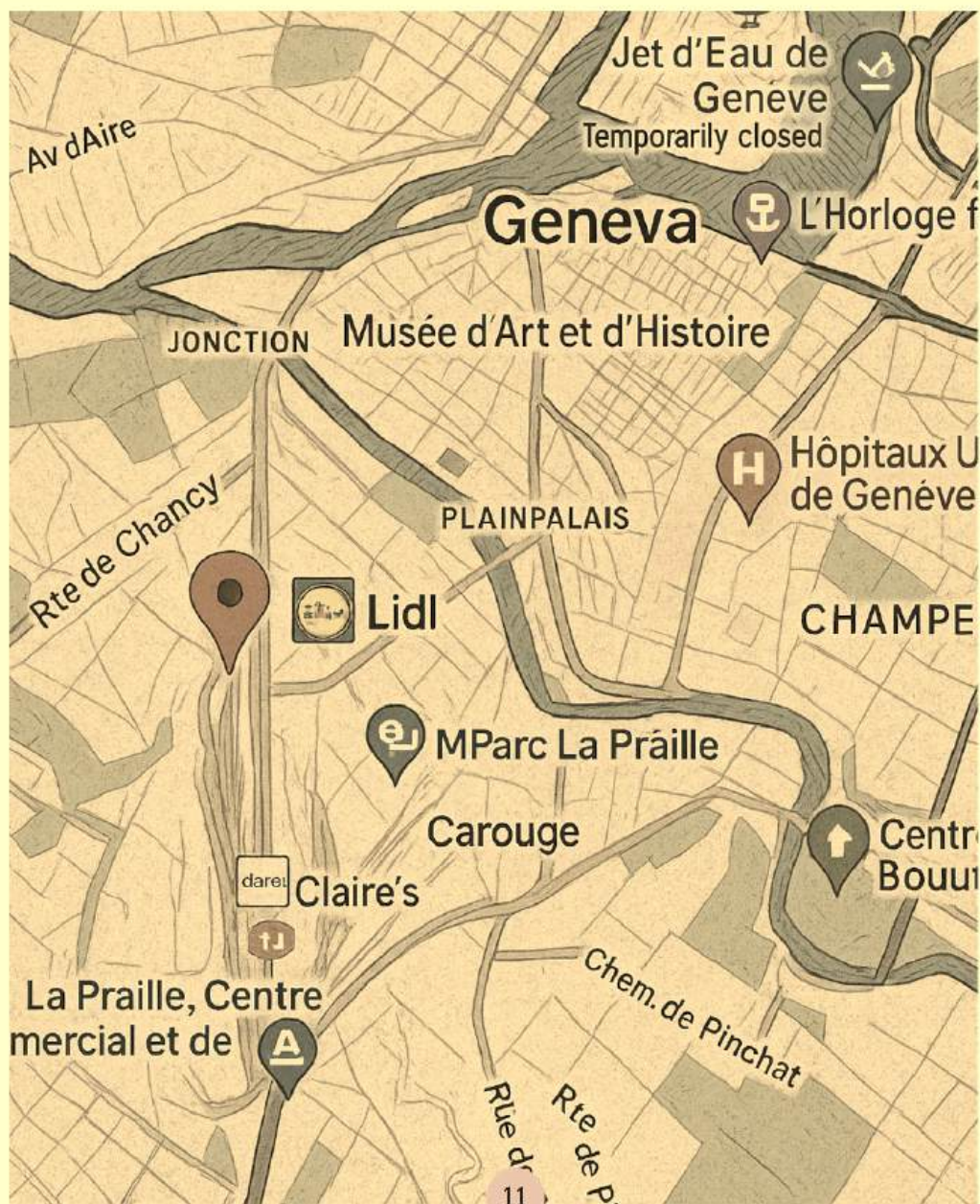




But then there were two things
that attracted his attention:
a key in an envelope marked
Geneva, and a worn address
book filled with codes.

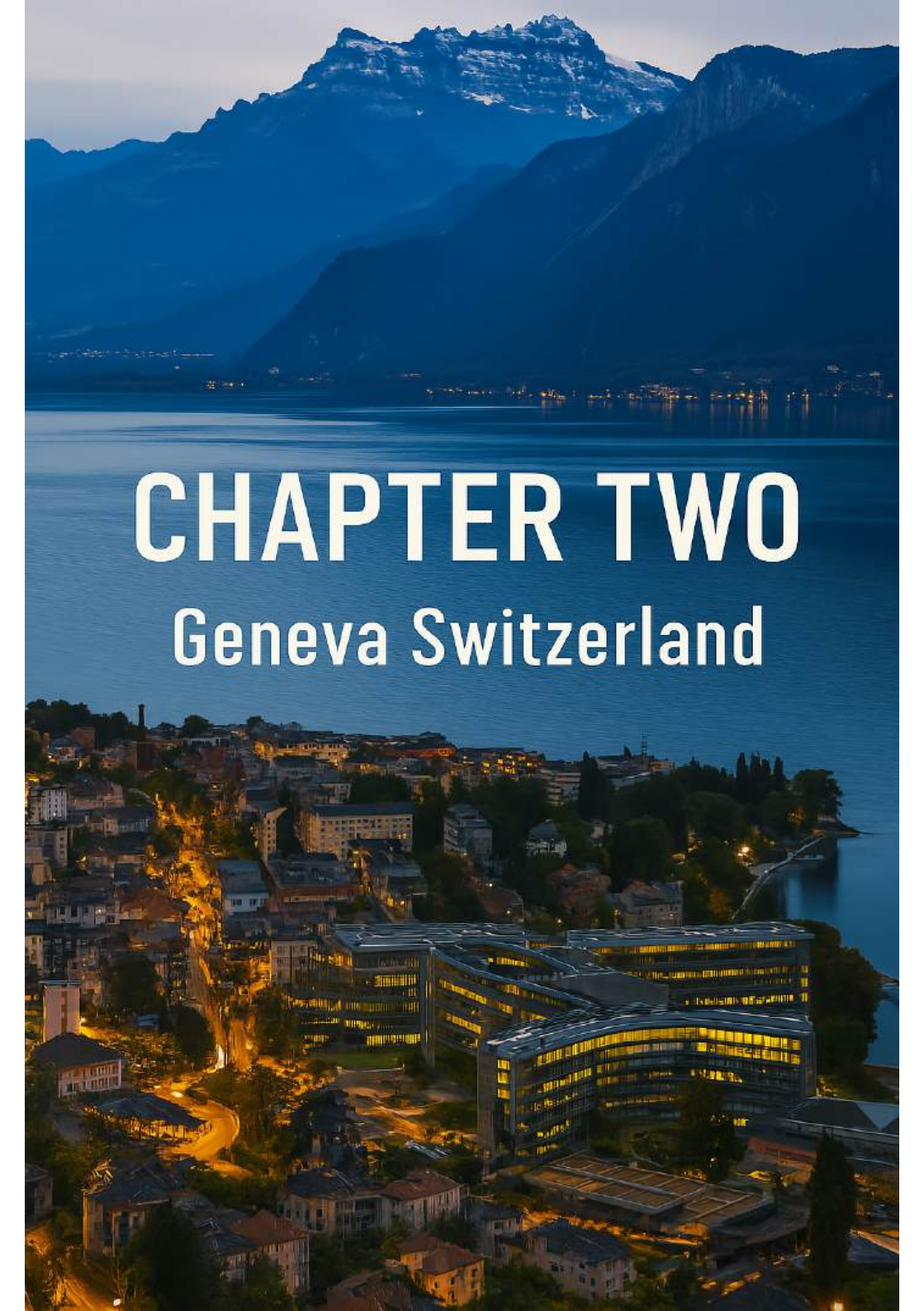


After some effort he recognised certain numbers as being postal codes, one of which intrigued him. He recognised it as Swiss, and more precisely that of Geneva. He checked it out, it was situated near the International Airport. He then Googled a map of Geneva and started a more detailed search. It not a banking district, but mostly warehouses, amongst which he spotted Ports Fracs et Entrpôts de Genève S.A., a free port.





The Ports Fracs et Entrepôts de Genève was a highly secretive vault for the very rich with an estimated 100 billion dollars worth of fine art objects stored in safekeeping. It was a short step to learn the key belonged to one of the many Belizean company he had created: Atlantic Fine Arts, of which he was managing director, like for many offshore companies he had setup for clients like George Wallace over the years.



CHAPTER TWO

Geneva Switzerland

Geneva Switzerland





Simmo rented a car and headed for Ports Franks in a Geneva suburb to the south of the airport where he found a huge fortified complex.

There he was met by Jean-Loiuis Favre, an account manager. After leaving his passport he was conducted to the secure inner sanctum.



ATLANTIC FINE ART LTD

PRINCESS MARGARET DRIVE
BELIZE CITY
BELIZE

Managing director B. Simmonds KCL, LL.M

Dear Sirs,

Please beinformed that I Barry Simmonds managing director of Atlantic Fine Art will visit your facilities tomorrow to inspect objects stored in your secure zone on behalf of our company.

Yours very truly,

Barry Simmonds

Partner, Simmonds and Young
Law Offices, Belize City



On a hunch Simmo booked a flight to Geneva that evening via Panama and dispatched a letter by fax to Ports Frangs de Genève.

Ibiza, Balearic Islands, Spain

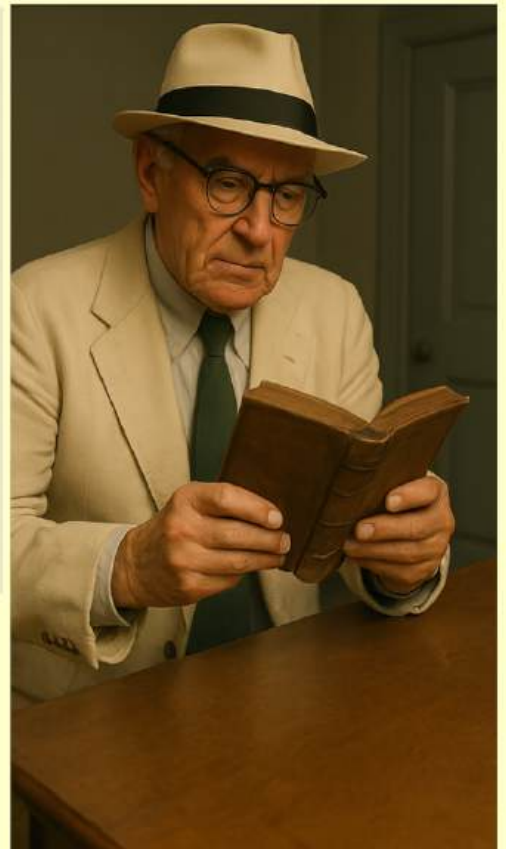


Simmo dreamily thought about his retirement villa in Ibiza, owned by a British Virgin Islands company he had created along with a bank account in which Sir Patrick Kennedy had deposited his first payment for the Wallace Codex and the rest following once Anna's authentication tests were completed. He would soon be a rich man and far from Belize, which he now saw as a threatening tropical backwater.

Favre led Simmo through a maze of corridors where they stopped at a steel door and Favre invited Simmo to open the door with his key.



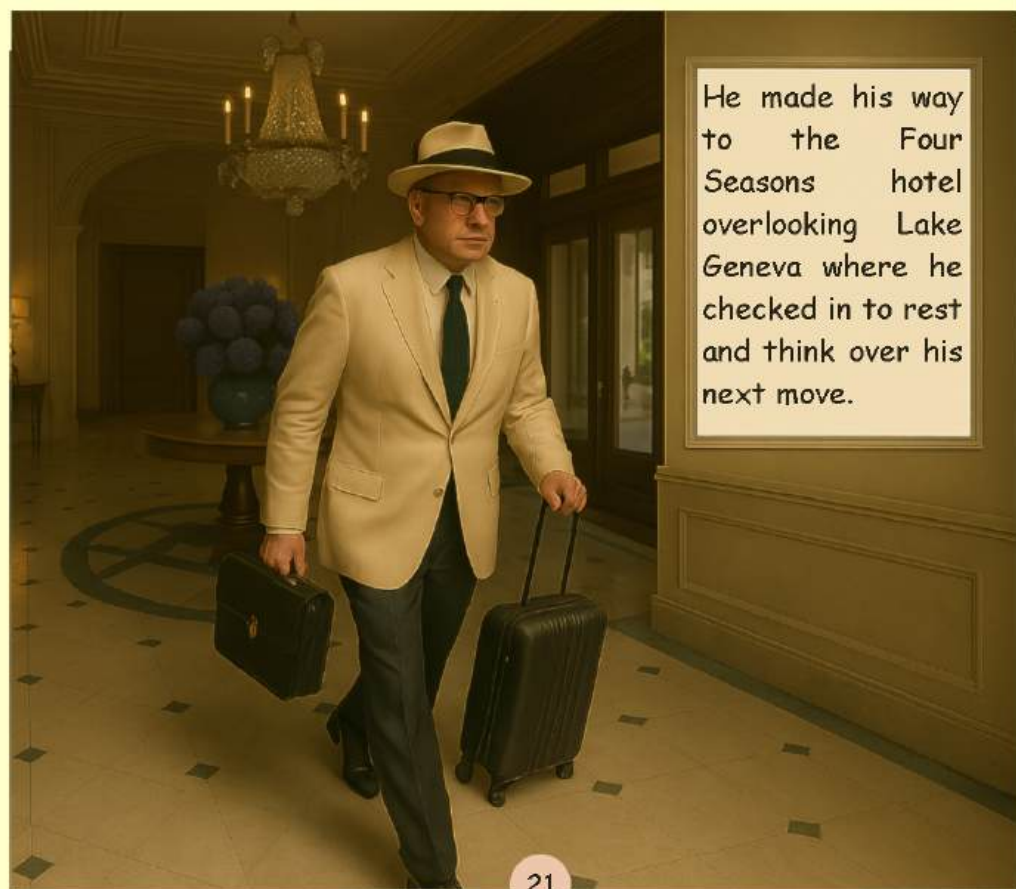
Favre pointed him to a space between the larger cases where a single wooden box lay. "Would you like me to have it brought to a private viewing room?" he asked. Simmo nodded. A storeman then appeared with a trolley, carefully placed the box on the platform and led the way to an adjacent room in the corridor where he carefully placed the case on a table. "I'll have it opened," announced Favre. "Then we'll leave so you may examine the contents in private. When you're ready just ring the bell," he said pointing to a button by the door.



The wooden crate contained a red velvet lined box which he carefully took out. He was puzzled and on opening it he discovered what appeared to be an Aztec Codex, probably dating from the time of the Spanish Conquista.



Simmo bid goodbye to Favre and quit the Ports Francs with the codex in his briefcase.





Simmo needed to authenticate the codex and find a buyer who would respect the need for confidentiality. As he looked out over the lake a cruise ship passed, it reminded him of a meeting a couple of years earlier in Belize City with a wealthy banker and collector, Sir Patrick Kennedy, who was accompanied by a well-known Parisian antiques dealer, Scott Fitznorman, and an archaeologist, Anna Basurko, at a reception to celebrate Belize's National Day.



Kennedy had arrived aboard his motor yacht, the *Salvator Mundi*, freshly returned from an expedition deep into the Amazon. He had been accompanied by Anna Basurko, the Spanish archaeologist, specialised in the trans-Atlantic flota that plied goods and people to and from the New World. Scott Fitznorman, a friend of theirs, was also present, head of a Parisian Antiques Gallery known for its rare pre-Colombian and ethnic collections.

Simmo figured that a very wealthy banker would certainly be interested in a rare book, especially if it was authenticated as an Aztec codex.

He quickly checked his contacts, found Fitznorman's number and called him. Scott had not forgotten Simmo and was immediately interested by the codex, informing him he was in San Sebastian in Spain for an antiques fair. That was no problem for Simmo, who announced he would fly to Madrid, rent a car, and arrive the next afternoon with the codex.



Belize, the home to many fabulous Mayan sites, with its extraordinary museum housed in an ancient colonial prison, boasted a collection of rare jade masks.



The Museum of Belize in Belize City



Simmo, who had never been more than mildly interested in the ancient history of the Yucatan, decided he need to swot up before he met Fitznorman and headed for Payot, the largest bookshop in Geneva.

There he found a broad choice starting with two books, the first by Tatiana Proskouriakoff a Russian-American Mayan scholar, and the second by Yuri Knorozov a Russian linguist.





Back at the Four Seasons he settled down to read. His first choice concerned The Florentine Codex composed by the 16th century Spanish friar Bernardino de Sahagun.

It described the General History of the Things in New Spain.

The manuscript, he learnt, was certainly the best preserved of that period now held in the Laurentian Library in Florence, Italy.

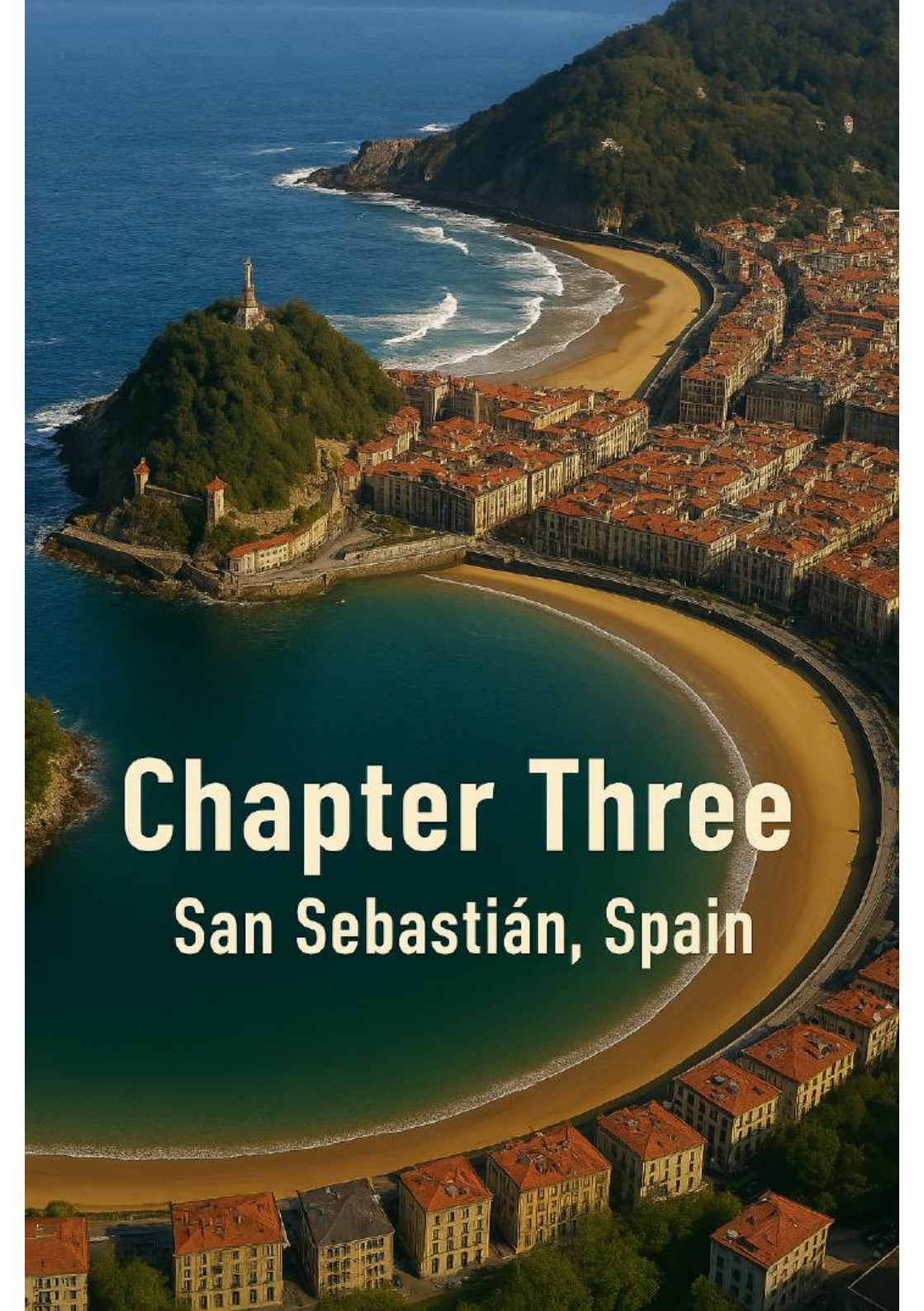
The entire work consisted of 2,500 pages produced between 1545 and 1590 when Sahagun died. The work was described as one of the most remarkable accounts of a non-Western culture ever written. The languages were Nahuatl, Spanish with Aztec images.

THE FLORENTINE CODEX

AN ENCYCLOPEDIA OF THE NAHUA WORLD
IN SIXTEENTH-CENTURY MEXICO



EDITED BY
Jeanette Favrot Peterson
and Kevin Terraciano



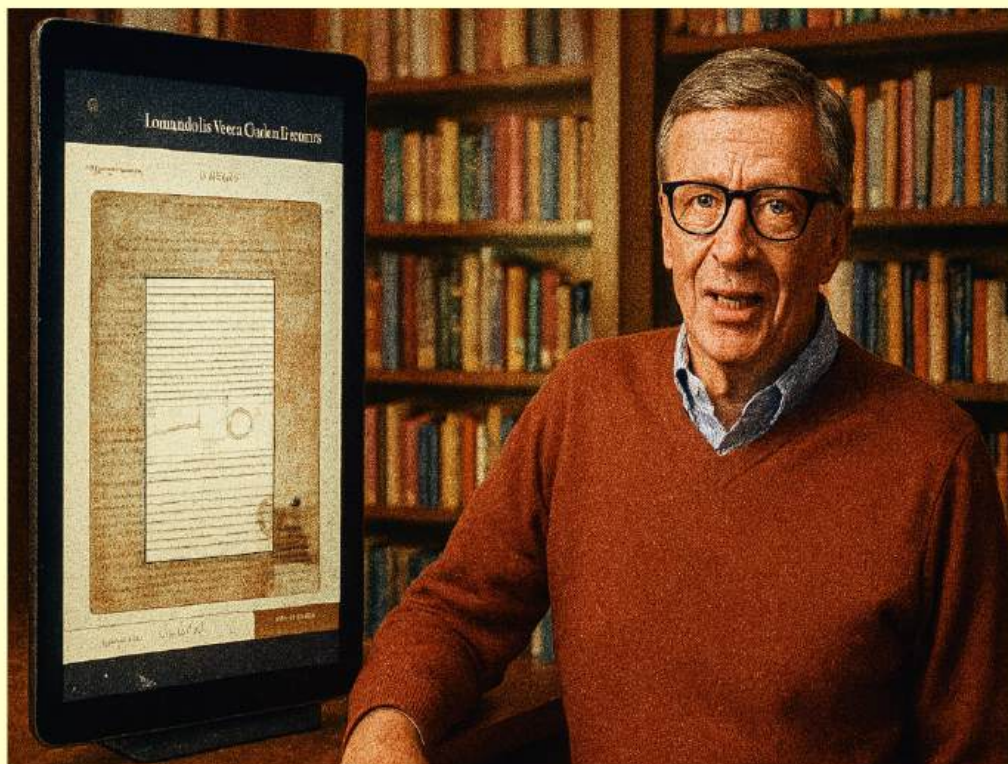
Chapter Three

San Sebastián, Spain



Scott locked the codex in the wall safe of his suite at the Hotel de Londres y Inglaterra. He then called Anna Basurko, briefly describing the manuscript and invited her over to meet Barry Simmonds for her expert opinion and help in determining the origin of the codex. Early that evening Anna excited at the thought of a remarkable historical find arrived at the hotel.





Anna informed Simmo that Bill Gates had paid \$30,802,500 in New York, on November 11 in 1994, for the Leicester Codex. Today it was worth more than the double that price.



A quick examination of the codex told Anna it was the real thing or a very good fake. It would need expert authentication backed by scientific analysis, by a specialised laboratory like Fine Arts Analysis S.A. in Geneva.



It would also need to be translated from old Spanish and Nahuatl, the language of the Aztecs, which had been latinized in the codex.

In reply to the question of what would be done with the codex, Simmo replied he would like to find a buyer, a private buyer, such as Sir Patrick Kennedy.

It would have to be a confidential transaction as different authorities could claim it as a national treasure, the Belizeans or Mexicans.

A close-up of the woman from the previous image. She is looking slightly to the right with a serious expression.

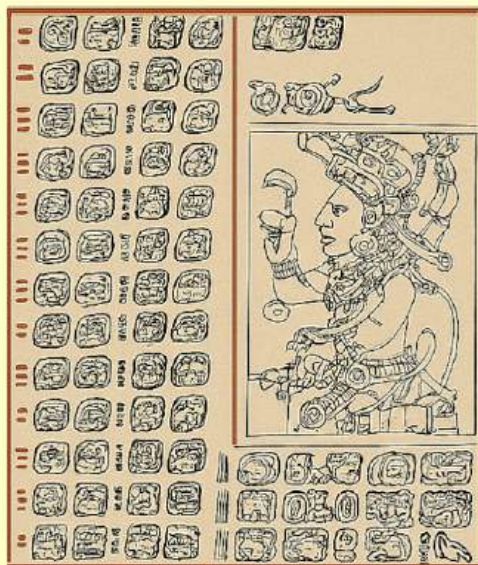
If you'd like me to contact Sir Patrick I can call him. I do believe he is in London.

A close-up of the man from the previous image. He is looking slightly to the left with a serious expression.

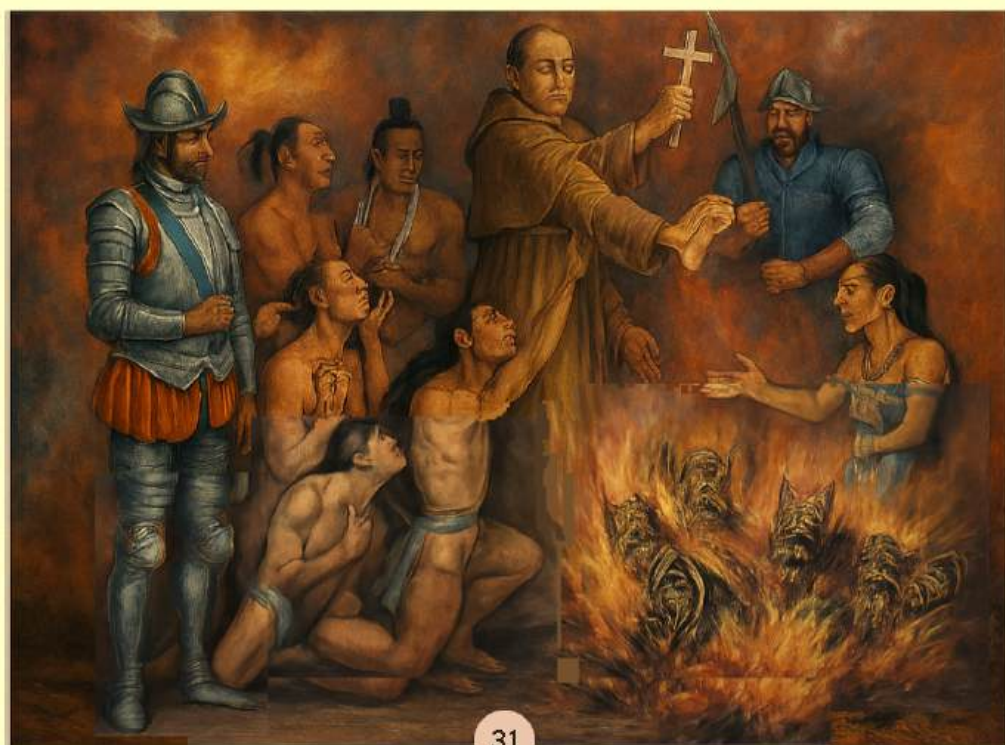
How much do you think the codex is worth Anna?

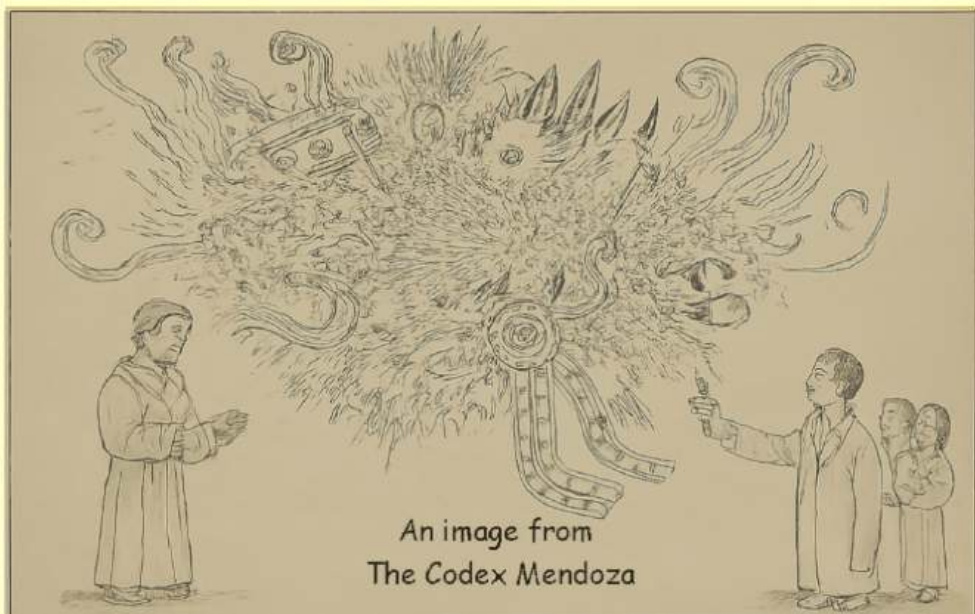
A close-up of the woman from the previous image. She is looking slightly to the right with a serious expression.

I'm only guessing. But if it's authentic, then it could be worth 20 million dollars or more.



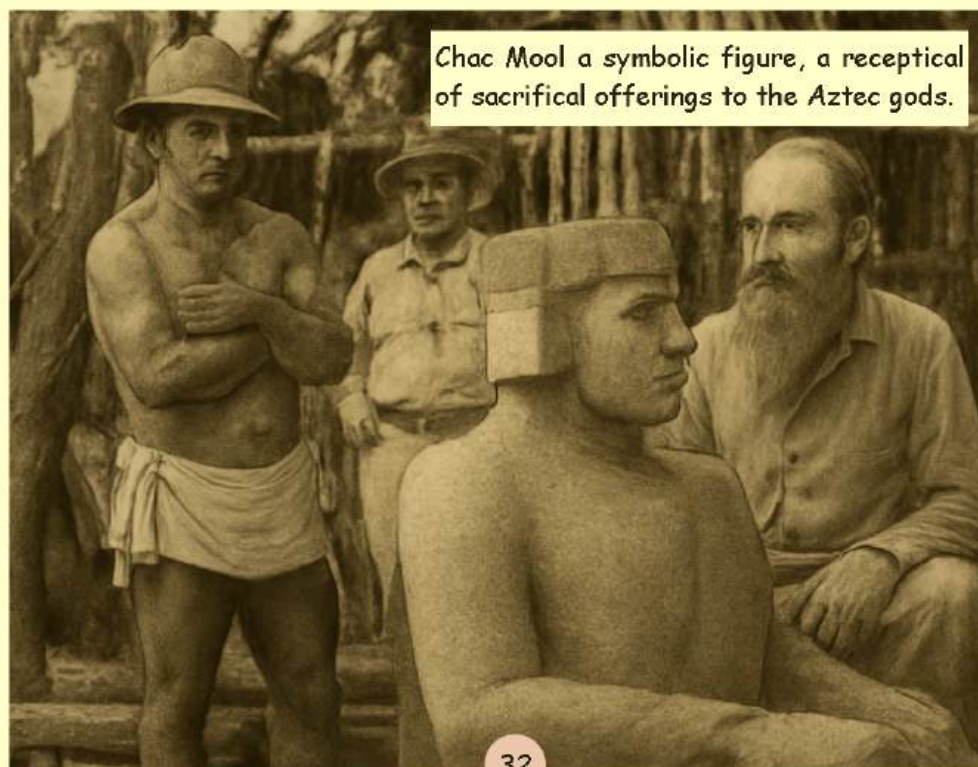
There were few books from pre-hispanic times even though the Aztecs and the Mayas had developed elaborate writing systems and produced many books as part of their highly developed and unique cultures. The Catholic Church and the Inquisition in New Spain saw these as conflictual with their religious beliefs and burnt great numbers of such books in acts of Auto-da-fé carried out by the likes of religious leaders such as the Franciscan friar Diego de Landa Calderon in the Yucatan, who would later become its bishop.



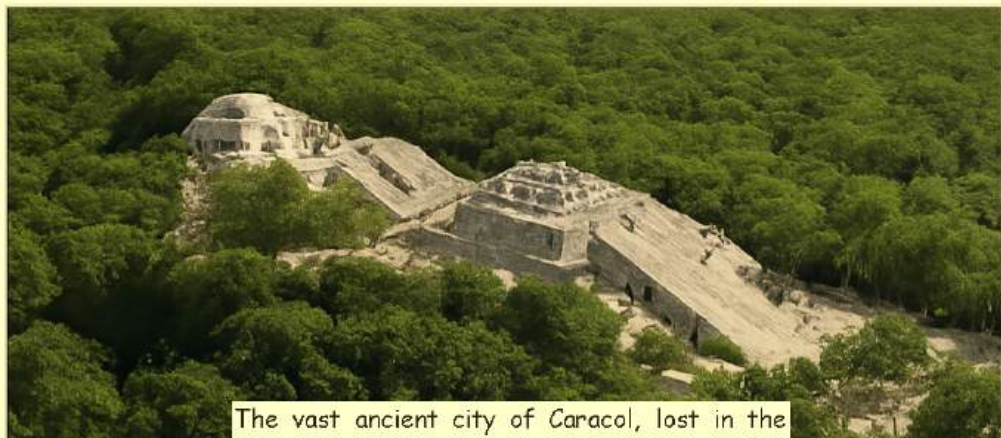


An image from
The Codex Mendoza

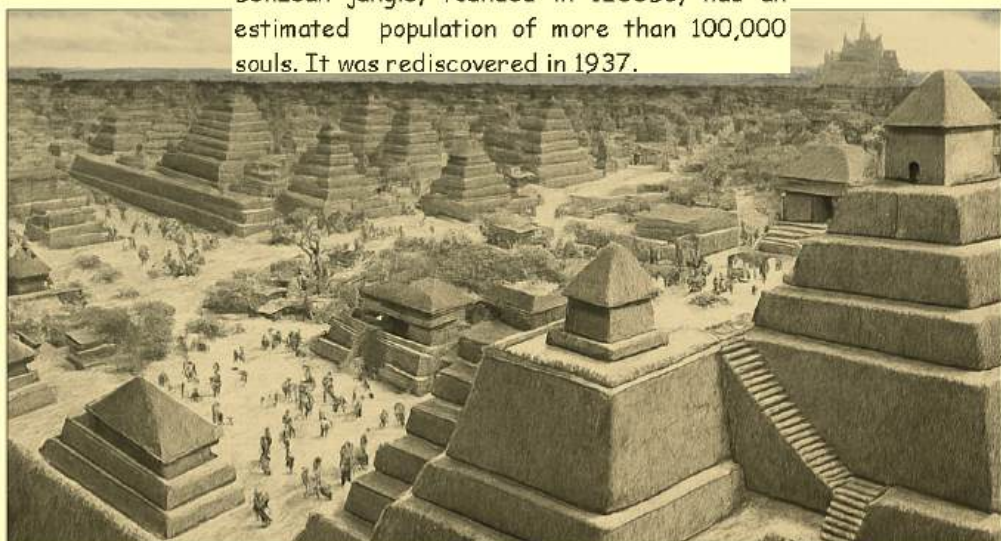
*Ull enobla de mihono Ula clowocianay, crano yoc leudione de loc Ghuatencas
Pas el Gmoxanuelico Pnathcatore*



Chac Mool a symbolic figure, a receptical
of sacrificial offerings to the Aztec gods.



The vast ancient city of Caracol, lost in the Belizean jungle, founded in 1200BC, had an estimated population of more than 100,000 souls. It was rediscovered in 1937.



Le Donta (B Mimder)

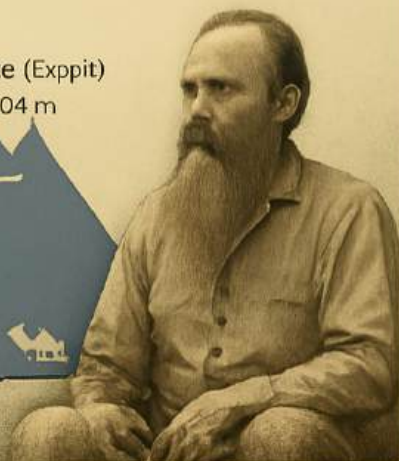
17.2 m

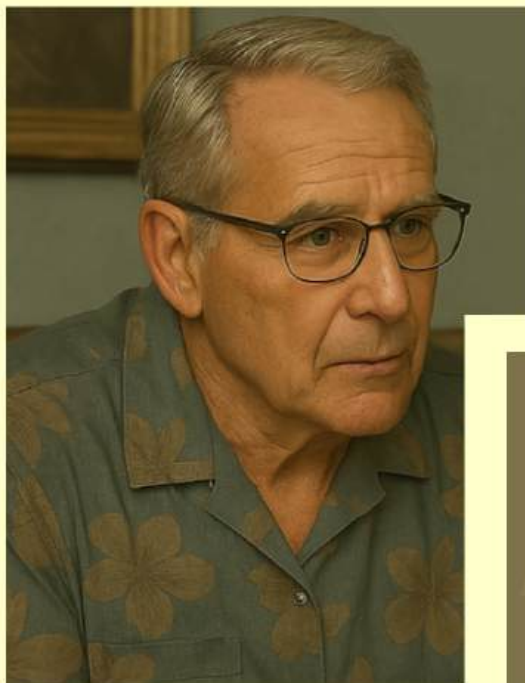
Kheite (Exppit)

104 m

Temphs V (Tiles)

2.4 m





The Wallace Codex, as Barry had started to call it, would certainly rank as one of the most important surviving documents of the early occupation of the Aztec and Maya regions of Mexico and Central America. A rare document of immense historical value.

It would undoubtedly be comparable to Sahagun's Florentine Codex and the centre of academic controversy.



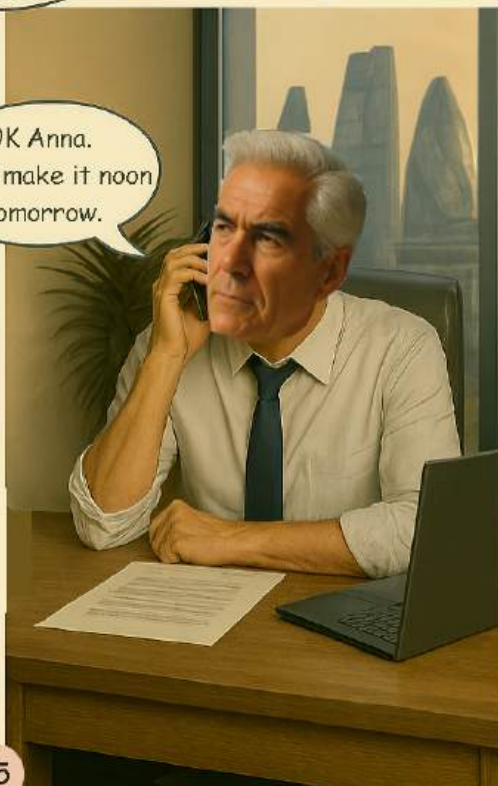
Kennedy would have the means to protect it and combat all claims whilst Simmo saw it as a means to provide himself with the wealth to live a comfortable life in Spain far from the dangers of Belize and the aftermath of the Covid pandemic with its winners and losers.

Sir Patrick was head of the INI Banking Corporation, a worldwide financial institution with holdings in London, Amsterdam, Hong Kong and Moscow. He was also a philanthropist and an art collector. Anna had worked on one of his projects in Amazonia when his yacht acting as a research vessel had been the base for a TV documentary entitled "Indians" two years earlier.



Sir Patrick I've discovered something I think you'd like to see.

OK Anna. Let's make it noon tomorrow.



Anna told Sir Patrick the story of Barry Simmonds and how they were in San Sebastian with Scott Fitznorman at the antiques fair. Pat implicitly trusted Anna and was immediatly interested and agreed to fly in the next day from London's City Airport in his private jet to talk with Barry and examine the codex.

San Sebastian Airport in
Spain's Basque Country



Less than
an hour
later they
arrived at
the hotel
in
downtown
San
Sebastian.





Early that morning Scott retrieved the Codex from the wall safe and returned it to Simmo who during the night had set up a company in a Carribean tax haven together with an offshore bank account.

The ownership of the codex was effectively transferred to that company, which could then bank the payment from Kennedy, if an agreement was concluded, documented by Simmo and signed by both parties.



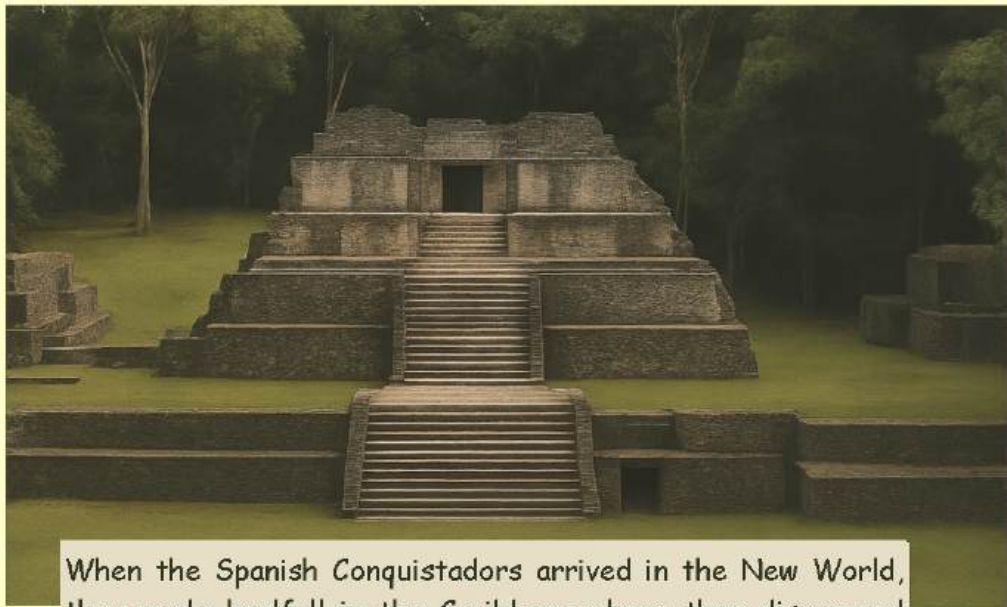
KING'S
HOTEL
KING'S HOTEL

Coca-Cola
DOLLAR GROCERY SHOP

PHARMACY

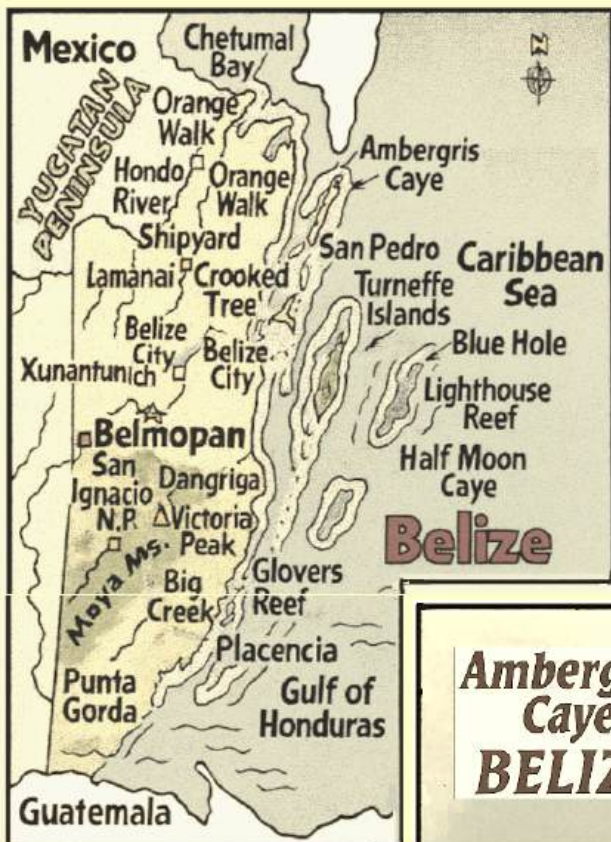
Chapter Four

Belize City, Belize



When the Spanish Conquistadors arrived in the New World, they made landfall in the Caribbean where they discovered civilisations that had already grown and prospered for more than two thousands years. The Aztecs and Mayas had built great cities, built empires, and had their own history and science described in countless books we now know as codices.





The Maya had flourished in what we now know as the Yucatan Peninsula made up of the modern states of Mexico, Belize and Guatemala. To the east lies the Mayan Riviera, a vacation paradise where tourists flocked from all parts of the world, amongst them Russians, many bringing big money with them.

Off the mainland of Belize lies Ambergris Caye with its capital San Pedro made famous by Madonna. Where the hot money from the Caribbean Laundromat flowed, invested in construction projects, one of which was Simmo's Golf and Residential Hacienda that promised him a well earned retirement on the Spanish Island of Ibiza



The Laundromat



The Laundromat washed dirty money whiter than white. The earnings from corruption, tax evasion, narcotics, illegal arms trafficking, the money stolen from the people by dictators.

A vast machine in which the City of London was implicated, directly or indirectly, assisted by an army of willing helpers: lawyers, accountants, banks and politicians.



Simmo was one of the helpers, facilitators, setting up shell companies, trusts and bank accounts, via an impenetrable dark web.

The offices of Simmonds & Young were situated in a quiet residential district of Belize City.



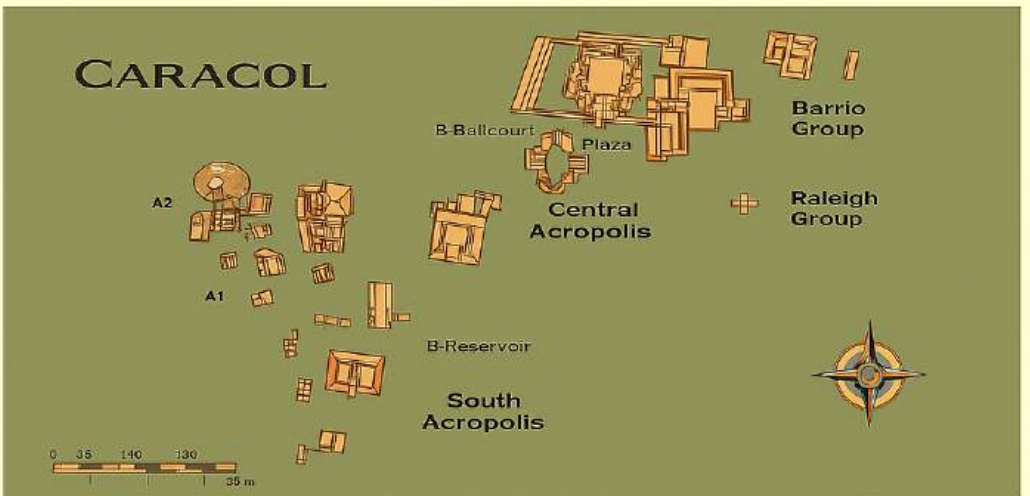
SIMMONDS
& YOUNG
.....
LAWYERS

For decades Simmonds & Young had been setting up offshore companies and bank accounts in Belize and other Caribbean tax havens, a lucrative business, and in more recent times for Russians, mostly corrupt officials and shady businessmen with Mafiya links.

After a visit to Flores in nearby Guatemala and the Mayan archaeological site of El Mirador, it was early evening as Barry Simmonds returned home to Belize City.



As he thought of how he'd soon be a rich man with the money he expected from Sir Patrick he dreamily drifted towards the middle of the road. He would soon be retiring far from Belize to his villa on Ibiza where he could forget his problems with Covid, the failed Hacienda Golf Resort on Ambergris, and his angry Russian partners.



He congratulated himself, after all Belize had finally proved profitably.



Suddenly a fast moving pickup appeared from behind and as it overtook it violently cut in sideswiping him as it passed. Simmo lost control...



...the Dodge swerved off the road, plunged into the deep jungle swamp, disappearing in an almost silent flurry of bubbles.





The pickup stopped. Two men got out. One of them, a Russian shouted, "Hijo de puta! Sedov is going to be very fucking unhappy. That's the second time you've screwed up! "Chingada! It wasn't my fault. El gringo perdida el control of the Dodge," replied the other, a Mexican. They quickly got back into their pickup and disappeared under the darkening sky in the direction of Belize City.



Three days later there was no sign of Simmo at his law firm offices in Belize City. His secretary Maria Scmitt was worried, normally, Simmonds kept her informed of his movements. She continued with the firms's routine work.

The following day she reported Simmond's disappearance to the local police. They were not too concerned. Many people disappeared for no reason.



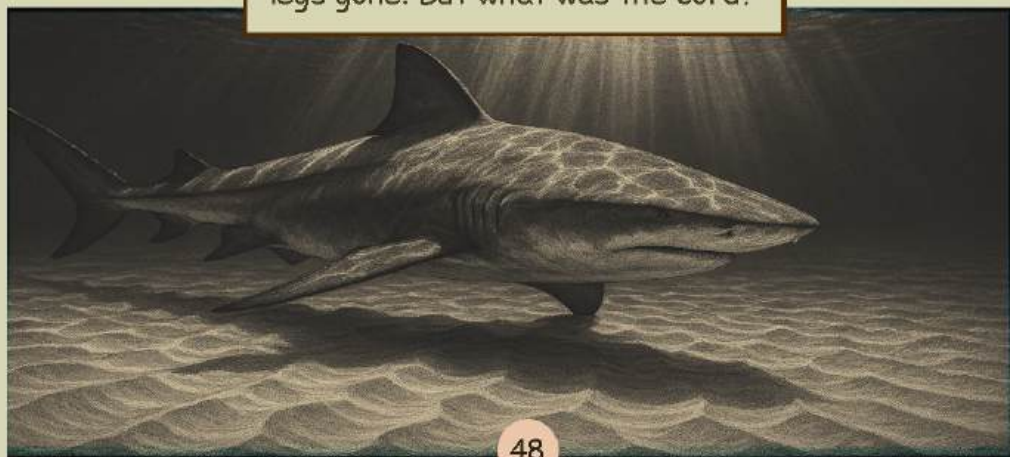
The Belizean police had a small budget, they were under- staffed and under-paid. There's was a small, poor, and often very violent country.



Vishnevsky's body was found on the beach to the north of San Pedro.



He was victim of a shark attack, his legs gone. But what was the cord?





Arkady Demitriev had added three victims in Belize to his already long list. Wallace had been waterboarded and drowned in his own pool. Simmo had died in a dark tropical swamp and Igor Vishnevsky had been fed to the sharks. Igor had been a longtime playboy on the Mayan Riviera as he sought out investments for his Russian friends with the help of Wallace and Simmonds..





Vishnevsky, a former banker, had persuaded a number of top level Russian officials, dreaming of retirement in the sun, to invest in a golf complex near San Pedro: The Ambergris Golf & Residential Hacienda, being developed by Wallace and Simpson. The trouble was no one had ever imagined the Covid pandemic, its lockdowns, and the collapse of tourist arrivals and potential buyers.



The region had a fantastic future. It was all win-win.



The Mayan Riviera, Mexico



The Russian airline Aeroflot had regular flights from Moscow to Cancun, flying in well-heeled vacationers.

It was also a change from the misery of places like Venezuela and Cuba, attracting Russian expatriats working in those benighted lands.





Igor Vishnevsky seduced visitors, Russian bankers and their wives, managers of state owned enterprises, with stories of how fortunes were to be made investing in real estate, the kind of place where they could retire and live like latter-day princes.

They could open bank accounts and set up shell companies as owners of their future properties far from prying eyes.



It was a paradise on Earth. What could possibly go wrong...?



Wuhan, China, 2020

In a Chinese city on the otherside of the world, a new virus appeared. Soon it spread to Europe and then the USA. Authorities panicked, then declared nationwide lockdowns. Airline traffic ground to a halt, tourists disappeared, vacations centres emptied, hotels and restaurants closed. Small countries like Belize, which depended almost entirely on tourism, were transformed into ghost towns.



A panoramic view of Moscow at dusk. The Spasskaya Tower of the Moscow Kremlin, topped with a red star, stands prominently on the left. To its right is the tall, white Spasskaya Tower of the Moscow State University. The foreground shows a wide road with streetlights and a row of trees. The sky is a clear, pale blue.

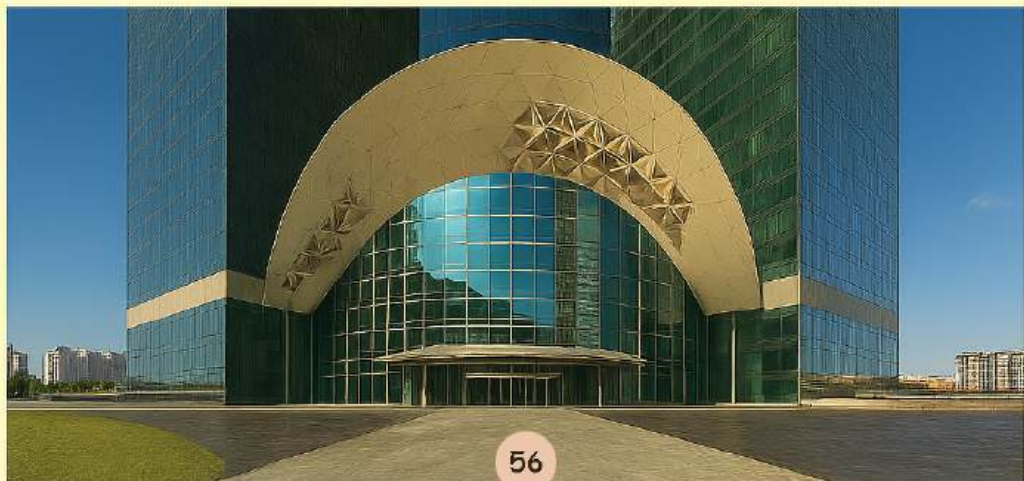
Chapter Five

Moscow

The Kremlin



Moscow's Financial District

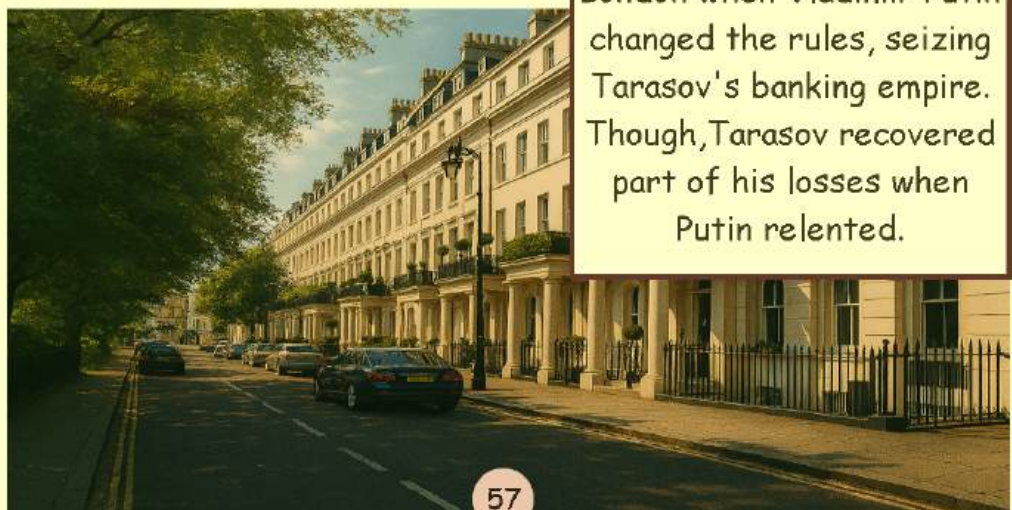




Life was dangerous in Moscow as Kennedy's friend and associate had discovered.



Sergei Tarasov had fled to London when Vladimir Putin changed the rules, seizing Tarasov's banking empire. Though, Tarasov recovered part of his losses when Putin relented.





There were some very unhappy people in Moscow who were not known for their understanding. They had put a lot of money into the Golf Hacienda and they wanted their money back...

быстро!

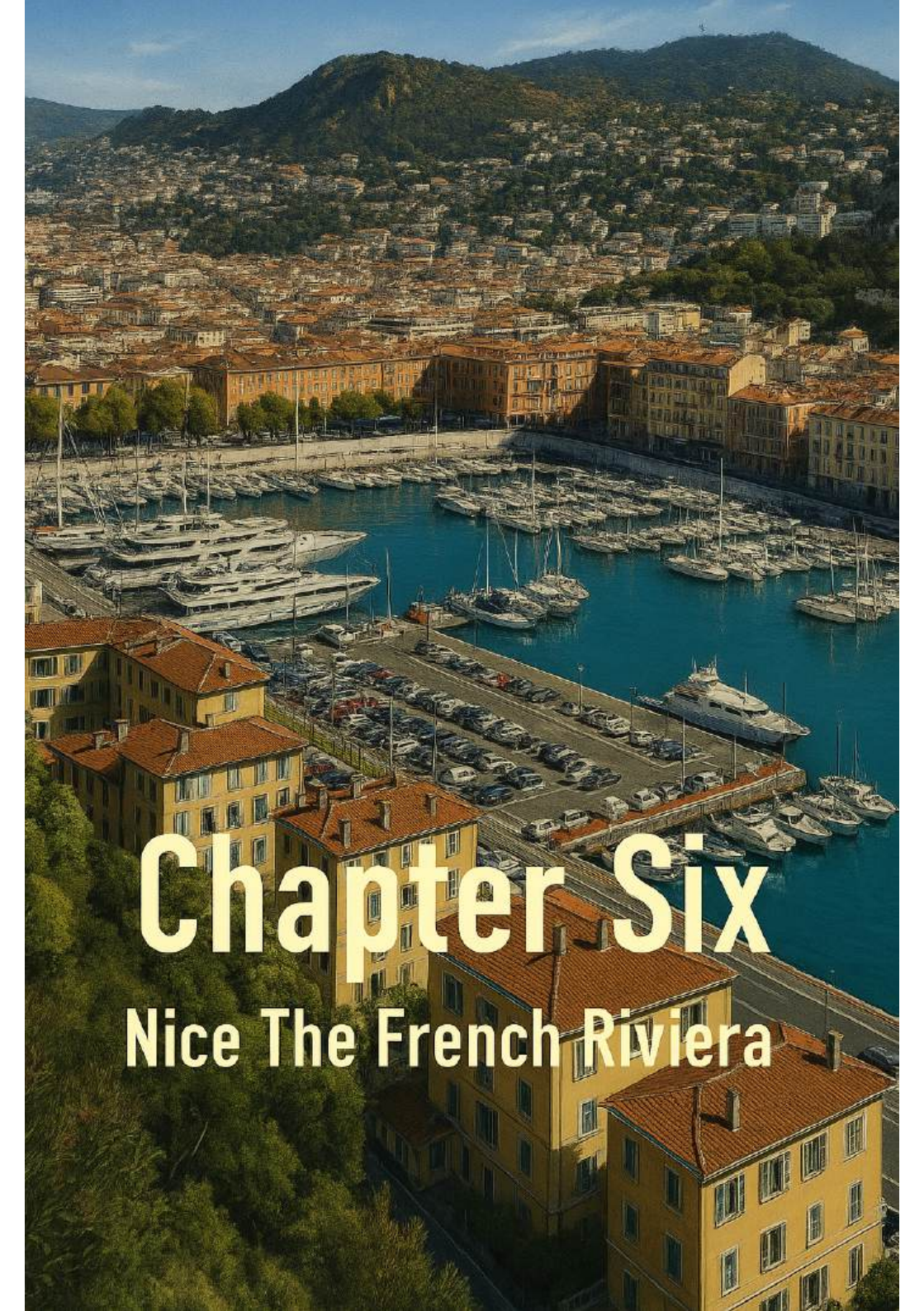




It was late in the evening when Sedov called Dimitriev from Moscow. He was angry, his friends were angry. Vishnevsky had screwed-up, scammed by a gang of shit smoking 'Rastas', more precisely Simmonds and Wallace. What else had Vishnevsky been hiding. He ordered Dimitriev to find out more about Simmonds' friends who had been traced to San Sebastian in Spain.

Dimitriev fearing he would be posted to some icy northern waste like Cherepovets promised results. He would use the FSB's men in Spain and nearby France to find out more about Anna Basurko. In the meantime he would visit Simmonds law firm in Belize City to find out more about the double-crossing business of Wallace and his friends with Vishnevsky.



An aerial photograph of Nice, France, showing the harbor filled with sailboats and yachts, the old town with its characteristic red-tiled roofs, and the surrounding hills. The water is a vibrant blue, and the sky is clear. The text 'Chapter Six' and 'Nice The French Riviera' is overlaid on the image in a large, white, serif font.

Chapter Six

Nice The French Riviera



Meanwhile, Sir Patrick Kennedy was picking up Anna Basurko at her hotel in Nice for a visit to the laboratories of LifeGen, a life science research company of his in nearby Sophia Antipolis. The object was to review her work related to the Wallace Codex.

Driving his Citroen DS cabriolet under the morning sun of the Riviera, he talked to Anna about her progress and the role of LifeGen and his projects.





Like many very rich men Pat Kennedy had invested in longevity, at sixty he wanted, like so many before him, to live longer to enjoy his immense wealth in good health.





Eternal life was an age old dream and Gilgamesh King of Uruk was the first known human to seek the Secret of the Gods. His story was recorded on the clay tablets found in the ruins of the Library of King Ashurbanipal of Assyria now in the British Museum.





Michel Morel was co-director of LifeGen with Henri Ducros welcomed Anna and announced that Luis Guttierrez, a botanist, would be arriving shortly from nearby Grasse.



Michel Morel informed Pat Kennedy that LifeGen did not have an in-house botanist, but worked closely with Phytotech, a research firm founded by Luis Gutierrez, which worked out of Palm Springs in California, and Grasse in France, the perfume capital of the world, situated about an hour's drive from Nice.



Luis, a Californian, proposed his aid in not only identifying the plants described in the Codex, but also offered his assistance with the Nahuatl texts. Nahuatl had been spoken by the Aztecs and other Precolombian peoples in Mesoamerica, since he had lived in Central Mexico as a student where the language was still spoken.



A few days later, Pat Kennedy invited Pierre Ros, a good friend, to lunch aboard his 90m megayacht anchored off Beaulieu-sur-mer.

Pierre was the head of the Faculty of Science at the St Charles Campus of Marseille-Aix University, which had successfully carried out authentication works for Pat's extensive art and archaeological collections.



Pierre was a fine gourmet and during the Champagne lunch Pat got down to business. One of Pierre's research centres, an advanced Biomedical Research unit in Montpellier, possessed a Cryo-Electron microscope.



We'd like to use your cryo microscope for botanical research into plants at LifeGen.

Pat explained how the Aztecs drank concoctions of blood and extracts from plants. Pierre spoke of the Zygophyllaceae family, a source of Nordihydroguaiaretc acid and other molecules.



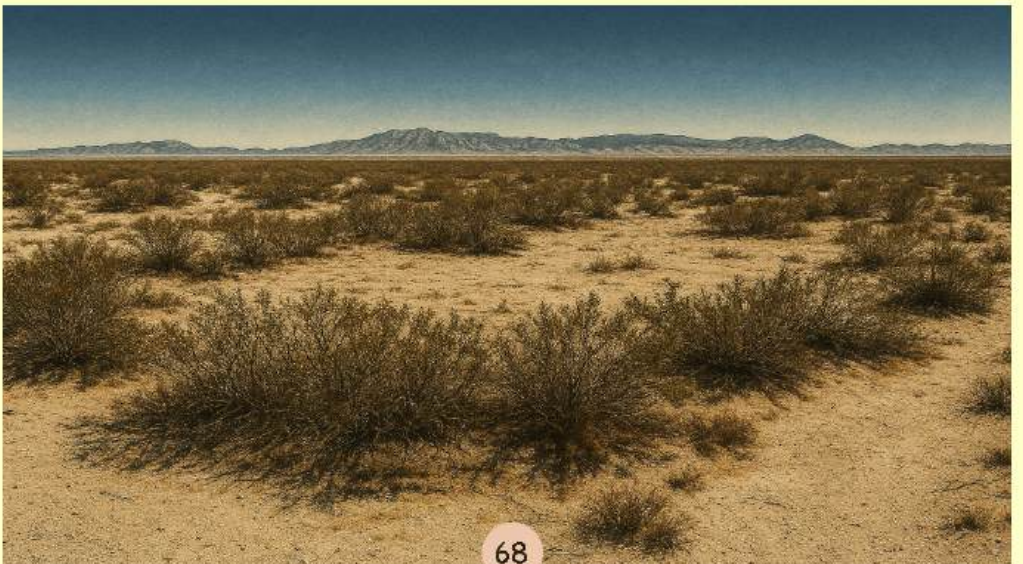
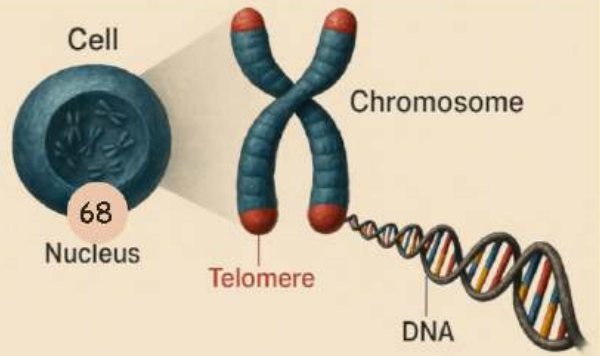
Yes, the Aztecs, like others were seeking eternal life. Unfortunately for them it didn't work.

Pierre then talked of their work on worms.





Scientists worked on plants and insects as they tried to turn off the ageing process. Amongst these were *Caenorhabditis elegans*, a worm, and desert plants like *Larrea tridentata* which lived many thousands of years.



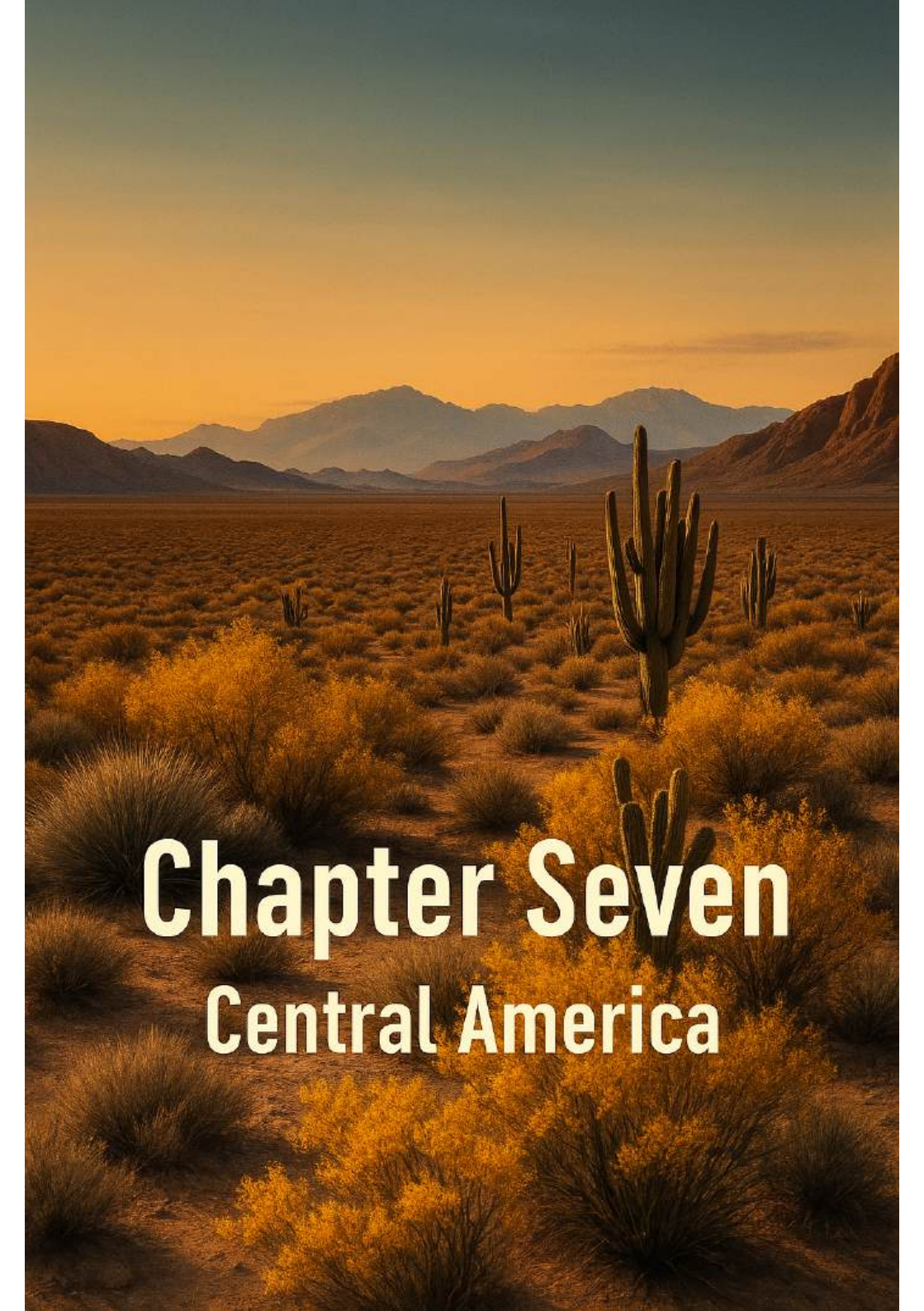
A couple of weeks later Anna arrived in Paris to attend a literary event with her friend and writer Dee O'Connelly at the Petit Palais. She met Sir Patrick to update him on the progress in the translation of the Wallace Codex and taking advantage of the fine weather they made their way to the Tulileries gardens. Anna confirmed the opinion of Luis Gutierrez that the codex was an herbarium, that is to say a catalogue of plants and their uses. She also informed him she'd accompany Dee to San Fransisco and attend a conference presented by Luis at the Getty Center in Santa Monica on the Aztecs and their extraordinary knowledge of plants and their medicinal uses, then visit Phytotech's Botanical Centers in Palm Springs and the Mojave Desert.





Immortality
Pat!
What else!



A wide-angle photograph of a desert landscape during the 'golden hour' of sunset. The sky transitions from a deep orange near the horizon to a pale blue at the top. In the background, a range of mountains is silhouetted against the bright sky. The middle ground is filled with numerous saguaro cacti of varying sizes and several large, bushy shrubs with bright yellow flowers. The foreground shows the sandy ground and more of these yellow-flowered plants.

Chapter Seven

Central America



Belize lay close to the heart of the Mayan civilisation, between Mexico and Guatemala, a region rich in archaeological sites such as Los Abuelos that dates back almost 3000 years.





Mayan religious beliefs demanded human sacrifice with blood as a ritual offering of food. The victims were those captured in war, the most prized of which were kings. The removal of the beating heart was performed by priests, the blood mixed with chocolate and herbs was a powerful potion representing rebirth and drunk by kings and priests.





The authentication process of the Wallace Codex was completed in Geneva by a specialised lab that analysed pigments, paper and bindings. In addition carbon 12 and 14 testing confirmed it dated from the early post-Conquest period, circa 1565.





Russian diplomatic interests in Belize were represented by Arkady Demitriev, a commercial counselor at the Embassy of the Russian Federation in Mexico City. Demitriev, in reality an FSB agent, took his orders from Oleg Sedov at the FSB headquarters in Moscow. Sedov concerned that the corruption of high level Russian officials would be exposed, ordered Demitriev to investigate the business of Wallace, Vishnevski and Simmonds. What had they been hiding and where had the money invested in Belize gone, and why had Simmonds visited Geneva and San Sebastian?





"Check inside,"
Dimitriev ordered. "See if there
are any bags. Check the glove
compartment."



Dimitriev's Mexican helpers were superstitious, but he insisted. They had no time to lose, soon the road would be busy.



They pushed the slime covered Dodge containing Simmo's grisely skeleton back into the swamp where it would be forgotten forever. Demitriev had recovered Simmo's backpack, his iPhone, a leather wallet and the vehicle's papers, all of which were sodden by the putrid waters. They would wait until he returned to Belize City where he would dry them out and search for clues linked to Simmo's mysterious voyage to Switzerland and Spain.



Anna Laura Basurko-Yneva

Real Académia de la Historia

C. Del León, 21

Centro

28014 Madrid España

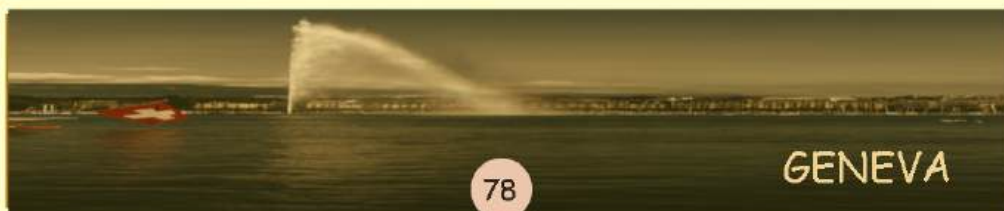


Back in his place outside of Belize City, Demitriev examined the contents of Simmonds' backpack. What attracted his attention was the visiting card of Anna Basurko, a Spanish archaeologist.

A quick check showed she lived in San Sebastian. The second thing was the visiting card of a certain Jean-Louis Favre at a firm called Ports Francs et Entrepôts de Genève in Switzerland. How they were linked to Simmonds was a mystery which Demitriev decided to investigate.

His first move would be to visit Simmonds' law firm in Belize City which could provide him with some clues.

The Royal Academy of History in Madrid, a venerable institution that dated back to 1735





So this is the plant the Aztecs used in their potions, *Larrea tridentata*.

It's endemic in the Mojave, Anna.

PHYTOTECH
CONSERVATION
ZONE

Commonly called the creosote bush, *Larrea tridentata* was a medicinal herb, a member of the Zygophyllaceae family, which could be found in the Sonora Market in Mexico City.

Growing in clonal colonies, it is one of the longest known living plants on Earth. The 'King Clone' colony, growing in the central Mojave Desert, is estimated to be 11,700 years old.

Also known as chaparral, it contains numerous interesting micromolecules, certain of which have been recently identified at LifeGen.

Thanks to the Cryo-Electron micro-scope at Montpellier University certain NDGA micromolecules discovered were being tested on lab animals at LifeGen which Michel Morel recently qualified as 'promising'.



The Getty Center
Los Angeles California



Demitriev was puzzled by the presentation on medicinal and aromatic plants given by Luis Guttierrez. What was the link to Simmonds? Who was Anna Basurko's friend Dee O'Connell? He needed to learn more and the person who could help him was Nikita Gulyayev, the cultural attaché in Mexico City. She was a specialist in pre-Columbian history. But first he would follow the couple to learn more about their presence in California.



Arkady Dimitriev was fascinated to learn that two Russians were renowned for their research work on Mayan history, notably the deciphering of its script. Nikita Gulyayev, cultural attaché at the Russian Embassy in Mexico City had explained how Tatiana Proskouriakov and Yuri Knorozov, working quite independently of each other, had each contributed to our understanding of Mayan civilisation. Proskouriakov's story was more adventurous and less contentious than Knorozov's, but that was another story.



"There are no indecipherable writings, any writing system produced by man can be read by man." Yuri Knorozov



Demitriev followed them into the desert and set himself up on a bluff to observe Anna. She seemed to wander aimlessly around, stopping here and there to pick up plants. After some time they headed to a low building in an enclosure where a panel indicated Phytotech

Anna accompanied by Dee took a refreshing pause from the desert heat as Luis Gutierrez together with one of his botanists described the Mojave biosphere, one rich in a surprisingly wide variety of plants.



The Aztecs had an extensive knowledge of plants that Bernadino de Sahagun recorded in his Libellus, a knowledge that exceeded that of Europeans when Carlos V ruled over the Holy Roman Empire c. 1500-1558



Chapter Eight

Sophia Antipolis



Michel Morel and Henri Ducros reported significant progress on the work of extracting micro-molecules from the leaves of *Larrea tridentata* and especially variants of NDGA which together with a cocktail of other molecules they had been testing on laboratory animals.

Pat Kennedy instructed them to accelerate their work and to keep him informed of their progress.



He explained he was experiencing health problems and was not optimistic for his future, news that came as a shock to his LifeGen partners and Anna.

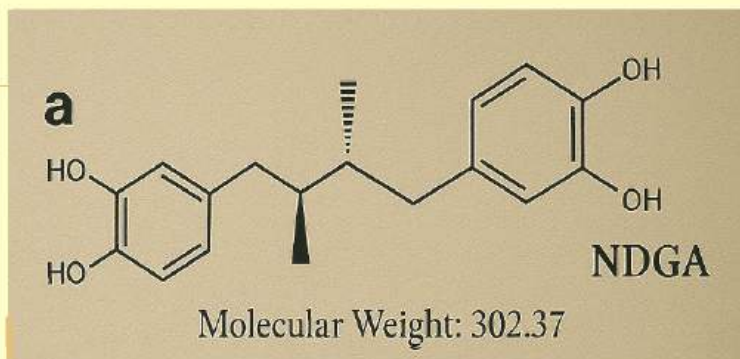


Desertic Chaparral herbs were rich in cyclolignans and had been long known for their medicinal values, which included antioxidants and anti-inflammatory characteristics.





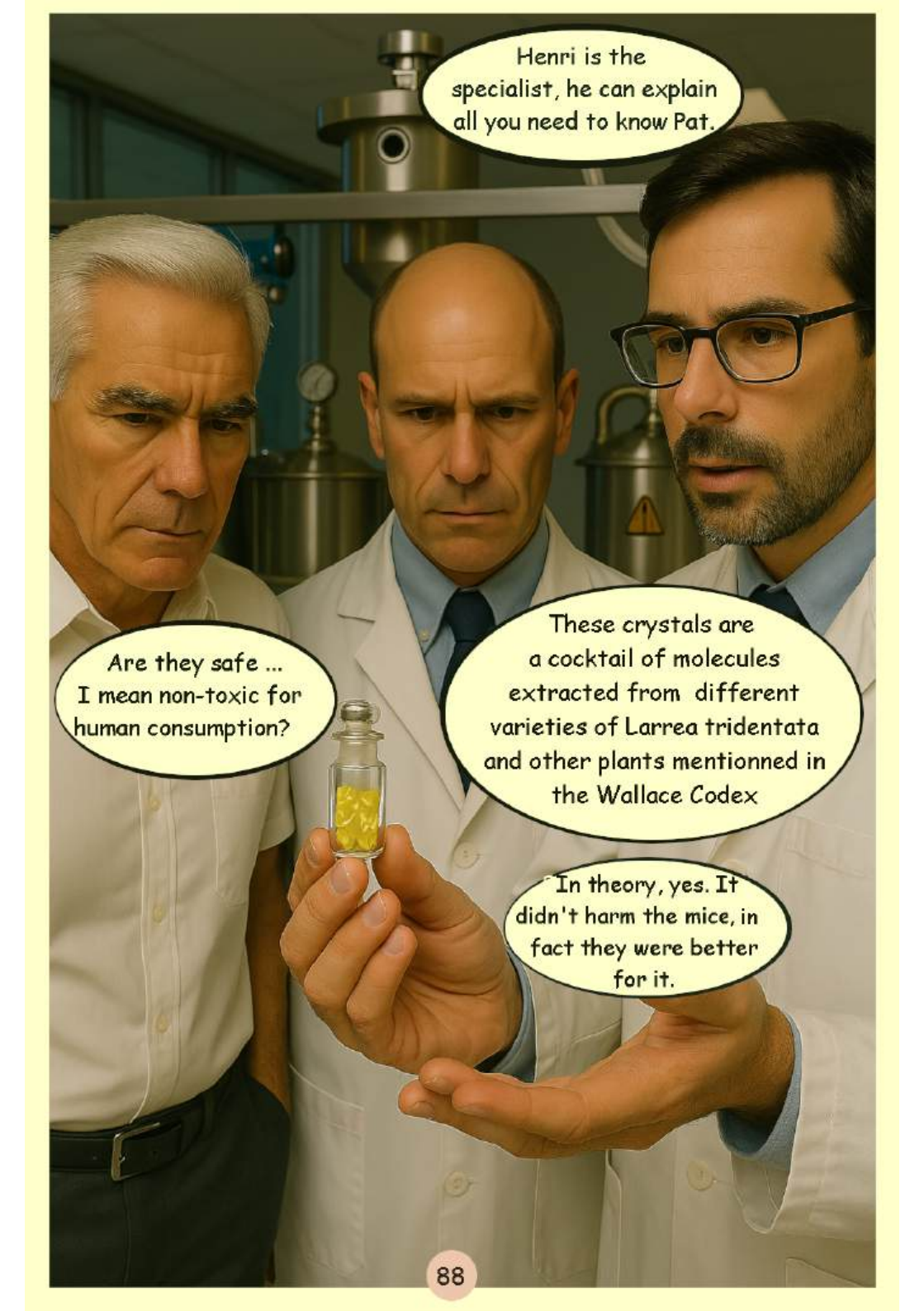
Various micro-molecules were extracted by a supercritical CO₂ process where a fluid has intermediate properties between those of gases and liquids. The extracted molecules were then crystallised in a reactor which were then prepared and tested on a variety of laboratory animals including worms, mice and rats with positive results. Mixed with *Pouteria sapota* the mixture had a strong cytotoxic effect, scavenging cancerous and senescent cells.





Michel explained that the mice not only lived longer with a life span increase of greater than 50% on average, but they were also rejuvenated, more active with greater vitality. The new molecule showed great promise, though more tests would be needed.



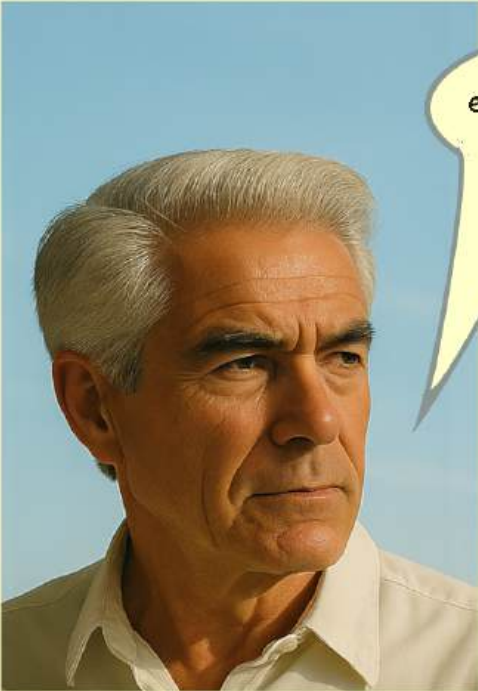
A photograph of three men in a laboratory. The man on the right, wearing glasses and a beard, holds a small glass vial containing yellow crystals. The other two men, one older with white hair and one middle-aged with a balding head, look on with serious expressions. The background shows laboratory equipment like stainless steel tanks and pipes.

Henri is the specialist, he can explain all you need to know Pat.

Are they safe ...
I mean non-toxic for
human consumption?

These crystals are
a cocktail of molecules
extracted from different
varieties of *Larrea tridentata*
and other plants mentioned in
the Wallace Codex

In theory, yes. It
didn't harm the mice, in
fact they were better
for it.



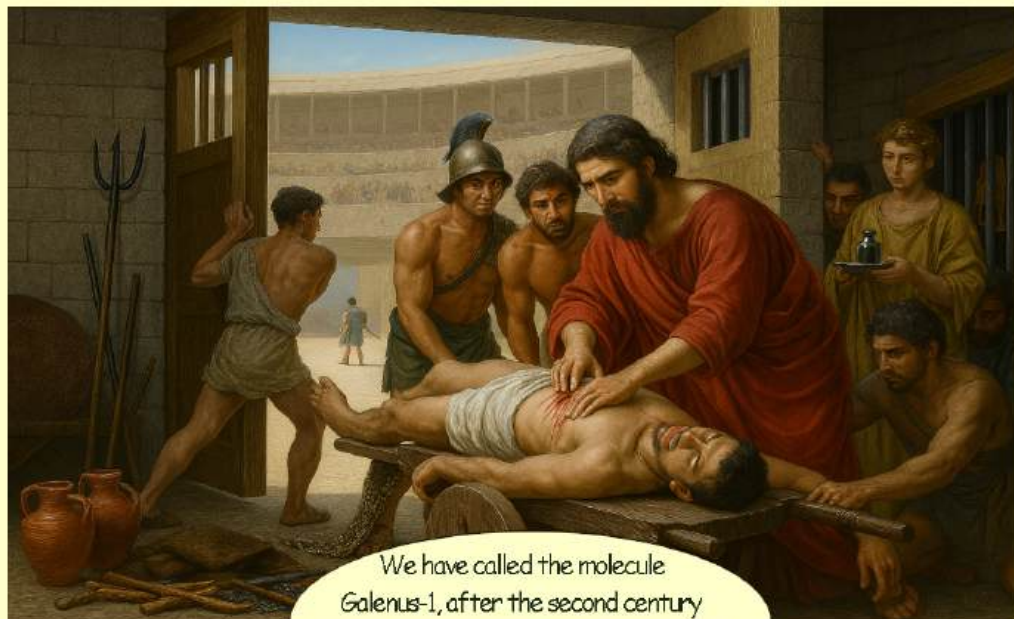
That's incredible, extraordinary. What's this molecule called?



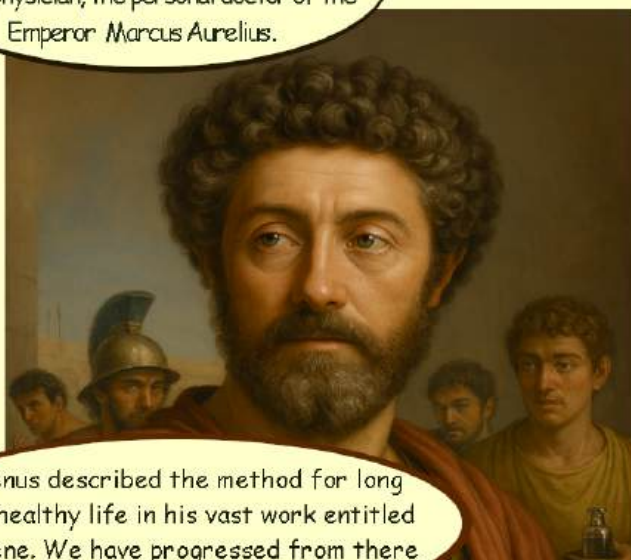
We've called it Galenus, for the moment. It's top secret. All of our staff have signed confidentiality agreements.



As you know Pat our industry is extremely competitive. James Herring is in the process of drawing up patent applications for the molecule and its compounds.



We have called the molecule Galenus-1, after the second century Greek physician, the personal doctor of the Emperor Marcus Aurelius.



Galenus described the method for long and healthy life in his vast work entitled Hygiene. We have progressed from there with modern science.

**LIBER PRIMVS I
GALENI. DE SANITATE TVENDA
LIBER. PRIMVS. THOMA IL
NACRO ANGLO
INTERPRETE.**



Vima fit ars. que corpoorii hominis
tuedia dictat albi in aobis olentum
ecrluma maxima praximabis funtq
Quarri alteram fanitras tunederastes
farum cotraxi potabitur apfiles. E-
luic imu officia corponis est ppo-
mataris bunii præcedituit & huius

We used the Cryo-Electron microscope combined with the super computer at Pierre's Montpellier University to identify micromolecules at near atomic level from the leaves of creosote plants identified in the Wallace Codex to isolate Galenus-1 elements.

You know Michel, I'd like to test Galenus-1. Prepare enough for one month for me.



Although Michel Morel was shocked by Kennedy's order, it was difficult not to obey. Kennedy, a very rich man was the founder and majority owner of LifeGen. At the same time the idea appealed to Michel, a scientist who realised sooner or later Galenus-1 would be tested on humans. The results on lab animals had been extremely positive and there were no visible negative signs. Michel acquiesced and promised Kennedy to provide him with Galenus-1 on the condition of close medical surveillance.



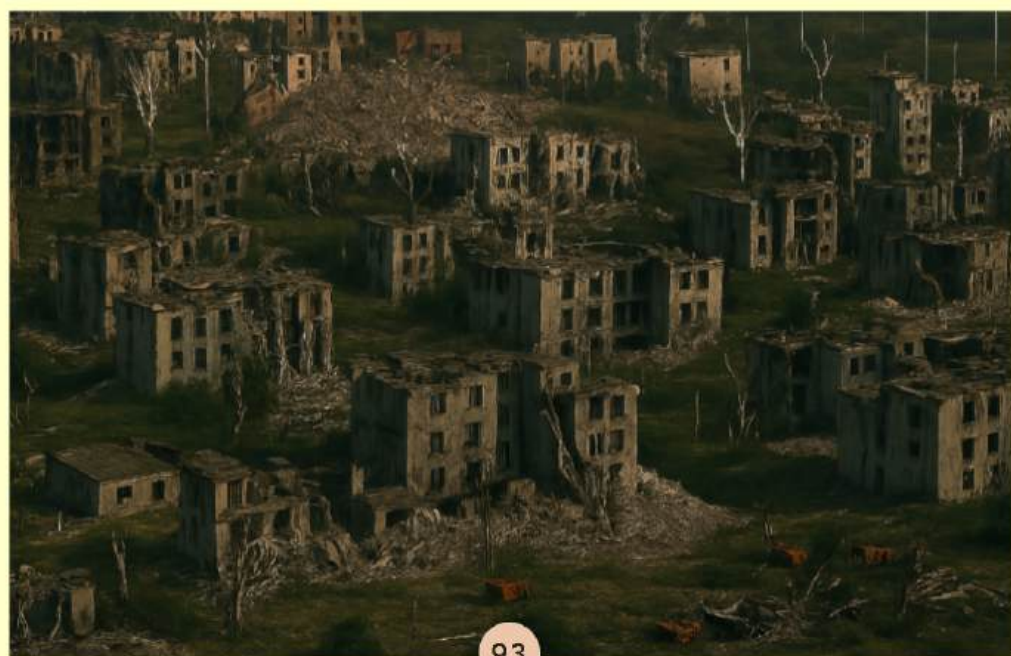
Kennedy, holed up in his palatial home on the Côte d'Azur in the Villa Contessa, relaxed.



He had received a month's supply of Galenus-1 capsules and savoured the moment when the Gilgamesh experiment would begin. In one month's time he would know if he had discovered the Secret of the Gods.



The world was in an increasingly desperate state: Ukraine, Gaza, and regional wars in Africa. Kennedy's vision was dark, it was why he had created Ciudad Salvador Mundi, a refuge high in the Colombian Andes to survive the coming Armegaddon.



Ciudad Salvator Mundi



Ciudad Salvator Mundi was a futuristic city built around a centre of science and knowledge, a refuge for human civilisation, offering protection deep in the ancient mines cut into the mountains where a community of wise and peace loving people could survive to build a better world after the coming apocalypse. High in the Andes far from tyrants and their wars, nearby to Barichara, and bathed by the eternal spring of the Altiplano.

Barichara



The Gift of the Gods

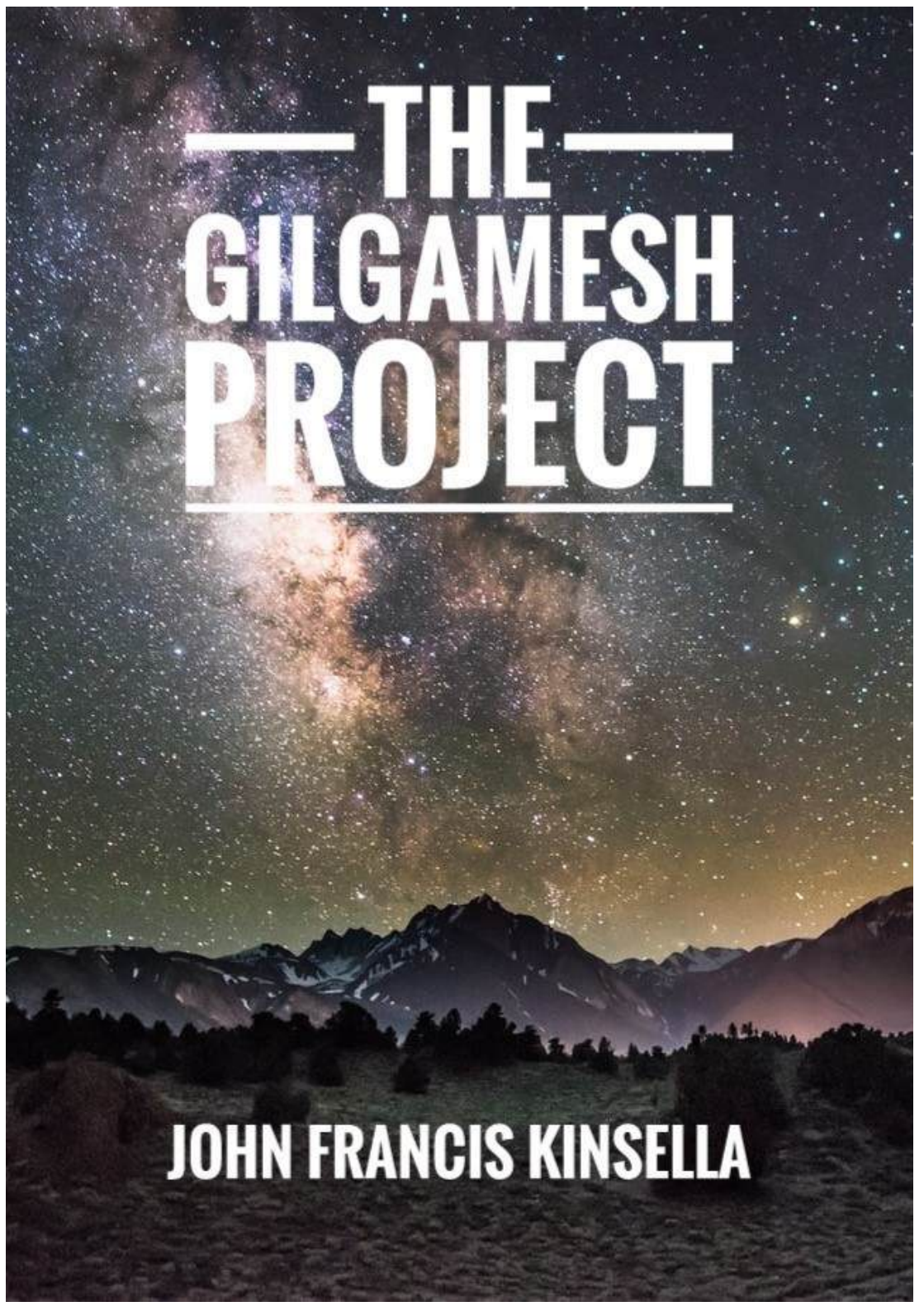
It was during a winding trip through Guatemala, Honduras and Belize that this story was conceived, The visits to the different pre-Colombian sites succeeded my travels throughout Latin America over a period of fifty years, an odyssey that commenced on Easter Island in 1973, born of my fascination with ancient civilizations, and how Englishmen men like Harry Pendel in John Le Carré's novel or James Wormold in Graham Greene's story found themselves entangled in strange adventures in tropical backwaters.

This story saw the light of day in five episodes, which were then compiled and published as 'The Gilgamesh Project'.

The following pages contain the original text of the first episode entitled 'The Codex'.

John Francis Kinsella

August 2025

The background of the entire image is a night sky featuring the Milky Way galaxy. The galaxy's core is visible as a bright, orange-hued band of light and stars, arching from the upper left towards the center. The sky is filled with numerous stars of varying brightness. In the lower third of the image, a dark mountain range is silhouetted against the lighter sky. The foreground shows a dark, textured landscape, possibly a field or forest, under the night sky.

— THE — GILGAMESH PROJECT

JOHN FRANCIS KINSELLA

CHAPTER 1

‘There are no indecipherable writings, any writing system produced by man can be read by man.’ Yuri Knorozov

BARRY SIMMONDS WAS UNEASY AS HE disembarked from the Iberia flight at Madrid-Barajas airport. Firmly grasping his briefcase and carry-ons he looked around anxiously as he emerged from the gangway and joined the thin crowd of arrivals hurrying along the seemingly endless one-way corridor, following the panels marked ‘Llegadas-Arrivals’.

Once in the almost empty immigration hall he tagged onto one of the unusually short lines and after a few minutes fumbled his passport across the counter at the control booth, squinting anxiously at the tight faced official through his thick glasses, wishing he could light up a cigarette.

It was Wednesday morning, June 24, a few days since Spain’s frontiers had been relaxed following a draconian Covid 19 lockdown, but it wasn’t the virus that worried him, nor was it the fact that the UK had officially quit the EU and his British passport would soon, he feared, have the same value as that of a banana republic or some other third world country.

He needn’t have worried, the attention of the Spanish police was fully focused on the health of the arriving travellers, a mere trickle compared to the pre-pandemic flow, more fearful of incoming infection than on the watch for the usual drug mules arriving from Central America on early flights, scrutinizing businessmen and tourists, arriving like him on

the half empty flight from Geneva and other hubs for fever and signs of the disease.

Simmo, as his friends called him, was a long-time resident of Belize, a former British colony, a small country overlooking the Caribbean, wedged between Guatemala and Mexico, where he was the surviving partner of a small local law firm—Young & Simmonds Partners.

His business was legal services related to setting up offshore companies and bank accounts, the firm's clientele consisted mostly of those who wanted hide their money from the taxman, many of them were 'honest' tax dodgers, businessmen and the like, others were much less so, crooked politicians, officials and their mafiya friends laundering ill gotten gains derived from corruption, embezzlement, extortion and plain theft.

His rather worn, but handsome leather briefcase, contained what had been discovered at the end of a complex paper chase left by a recently deceased client of his, one George Wallace.

Wallace, a Londoner, had been a good client of Simmo's, for whom he had set up a good number of offshore shell companies over the previous decade or so, both in Belize and other Caribbean tax havens, for which he managed certain and often complex legal transactions.

Belize was barely ever mentioned in mediatised investigations into tax havens, it was too poor, less glamorous compared to the Bahamas or the Cayman Islands. In the book *The Panama Papers*, described as 'the biggest leak in the history of data journalism' by the American whistleblower, Edward Snowden, Belize was cited just twice, very briefly, and in the *Laundromat* it was cited just once in passing.

Wallace had kept a low profile, very discreet, maintaining nothing more than polite contact with his close neighbours, though he often entertained business friends, who included Russians, Cubans and Venezuelans, at his spacious villa that lay on the edge of the forest, between the Rio Bravo Conservation Area and the Crooked Tree

Wildlife Sanctuary, about an hour's drive to the north-west of Belize and its airport.

Wallace used Simmond's services to create the kind of legal fronts needed to manage his clients' business in safe havens, the safer the better. His business consisted of laundering their dirty money with the ultimate goal being investment in upstanding prime property in London and other European capitals, the trouble was some of his clients' dollars were simply too dirty, and even London, though it wasn't too regarding, had its limits.

Simmo had maintained a serious business-like relationship with Wallace. As a lawyer he provided legal services according to the legislation enacted in Belize, which gave him a lot of latitude since it boasted one of the most secure jurisdictions with regards to confidentiality and discretion for offshore companies.

The Belize International Business Company Register, through the Belize IBC Act, promised to protect offshore businesses and bank accounts within the jurisdiction of Belize. Stiff penalties punished any divulgence of sensitive and private information such as banking records or financial information about residents and non-residents, and all fiscal documentation was protected and guaranteed confidential within Belize.

In addition, Belize IBCs were not required to officially report annual accounting information or to file account audits. All information filed during the registration process remained with the licensed register agent. Therefore, all pertinent information about a company, that is to say the identities of its shareholders, directors, and owners, were expunged from public record.

The only documents that an offshore company in Belize were required to have on public record were the Articles of Association and the Memorandum. Both of these records existed to officially prove the incorporation of an IBC in Belize.

Unfortunately Wallace had been found dead by his house keeper, floating in the pool at his villa. An accidental drowning according to the medical report. Simmonds was the legal executor of defunct's estate, a task he had not anticipated given Wallace was barely 50 years old and in good physical form.

Single and without children Wallace always been a bit of a mystery with no heirs apart from a few distant and apparently hard up relatives living in London who asked Simmo's law firm to liquidate the estate, which mainly consisted of the villa.

Surprisingly, the balance in Wallace's account at his local bank account was of little interest, but it came with a safe deposit box, which Simmo had initially overlooked. When the manager at the Heritage Bank called about the closure, he recalled the charges due for the box were overdue. Simmo perked up, perhaps it contained something of interest and he informed the manager he would drop by the following morning at the bank's main branch on Princess Margaret Drive, situated in the downtown area of Belize City, a ten minute walk from his office.

He was not disappointed, besides a few not very interesting documents— deeds, insurance documents and the like, it contained a hundred or so thousand dollars in negotiable share certificates, treasury bonds, cash, gold coins and small bars, more than enough to cover his fees.

Amongst the papers was an envelope containing a key and the address of a bank in Panama City, which though it intrigued him he put it to one side whilst he finalised the inventory and concentrated his mind on the disposal of the deceased's estate.

He put the villa on the market at a price that ensured a quick sale and his firm a good commission, sold the shares and gold, and wired the proceeds to a law firm in London that would take care of the formalities for to whom it was due.

A month later on one of his occasional visits to Panama City, where he was to meet with one of his UK clients—in transit to his vacation home on one of the islands of Bocas del Toro, he dropped in at the PKB Banca Privada, part of the New York based Warburg Pincus private equity bank. There he presented himself to the account manager and was led to the safe deposit box vault.

Simmo was familiar with the procedure and with a minimum of formality he was led to the basement vault where with his password and key, and the bank's guard key, the box was opened. He withdrew the metal drawer and was pointed towards a private booth where he was left to inspect the contents.

Placing the drawer on the table he lifted the lid. It contained a substantial sum of money in different currencies, and a hard covered address book, about the size of the kind of pocket book that could be found on the shelves of any stationary store. It contained about 100 pages with A-Z index tabs, filled with what appeared to be coded addresses and numbers.

He had hoped to find something more valuable, but he contented himself with the cash which he slipped into his briefcase and the notebook into his pocket. He then signalled his departure to the bank employee who had been discretely waiting a few paces from the booth.

Back in his hotel room he counted the cash, mostly US dollars and Swiss francs, in large bills, almost two hundred thousand dollars. He then inspected the note book. It contained entries of what appeared to be account numbers, codes and abbreviations. He picked up his Samsung smartphone and connected to his Google Drive and opened a coded file, it contained a list of bank accounts he had opened for his clients over the years. He ran down the list and stopped at Wallace and compared the numbers. He quickly found one that matched and then several others. The abbreviations corresponded to the names of the banks, plus what he recognised as postcodes. The other numbers were the accounts and access codes.

Wallace's system was simple and by extrapolation Simmo quickly identified most of the accounts. One, however, puzzled him, it was a Swiss postcode, for Geneva. A quick check showed it to be an address near the city's international airport.

He Googled the map of Switzerland and zoomed into Geneva and the airport which lay to the north of the city. He switched to the satellite map, it showed nothing but car parks and warehouses. He checked for banks, but found none. He searched south, towards the city centre, then the surrounding suburbs, not exactly a banking districts. He continued along Voie Centrale and Route des Jeunes towards the border with France.

There was nothing that resembled the kind of place to stash money. Suddenly he spotted Credit Agricole, a French bank—not reputed for offshore banking. Next to it was KPMG, the international financial management firm. He was getting warmer. Then a large building caught his eye, it wasn't a bank, something much more intriguing, he recognised the name, one linked to a fine objets d'art scandal that had made headlines in the press—Ports Francs et Entrepôts de Genève S.A.

He checked out the address—Route du Grand-Lancy 6a, 1211 Genève, Suisse. The postal code 1211 corresponded to that in the address book.

Another search told him the Freeport was one of the world's most secretive sites. Its vaults held more than one million fine art objects worth an estimated 100 billion dollars, compared to the Museum of Modern Art in New York, one of the world's greatest art collections with some 200,000 works, which dwarfed London's National Gallery with its 2,300 paintings.

His pulse accelerated, he had that gut feeling he was on to something, something that must have been worth hiding, though art to his knowledge had not been one of Wallace's usual business interests.

Cross-checking the bank account that corresponded with the Geneva reference, Simmo noted it was linked to a company that he had set-up a

couple of years back—Atlantic Fine Arts. He looked it up in his file and saw that he was managing director, there was nothing unusual in that, he was the MD of numerous companies, a simple ploy that hid the identity of the real owners.

He looked at his watch, then impulsively checked the flights to Geneva. There was one leaving early that evening for Madrid with a connection to Geneva early the next morning, he called Iberia and booked a business class seat on the flight, at the least he could deposit the cash in a Swiss bank, a much needed contribution to his seriously compromised retirement fund, he figured Wallace would no longer need it.

He then carefully worded a mail to the Freeport informing them he would be arriving the next day to access his storage space. He signed it as managing director of Atlantic Fine Art and clicked send.

CHAPTER 2

SIMMO HAD CHECKED OUT THE EXACT location on Google maps and driving a rented car he found the Ports Francs et Entrepôts de Genève complex without difficulty. It was much larger than he had expected, consisting of four large buildings on the corner of Route des Jeunes and Route de Grand Lancy. The main building was a modern office style structure five stories high on Grand Lancy, behind was nondescript windowless building that looked more like a multiplex cinema than a warehouse. To the right of the main office was a long low two storey building behind which was another larger off-white warehouse that extended nearly half-a-kilometre down Route des Jeunes. The site was situated by a railway sidings about four kilometres southwest of downtown Geneva.

The Freeport was principally owned by the Swiss government with a minority holding held by a group of art dealers, collectors, freight forwarders and mysterious offshore companies.

There was not much about the buildings that said they contained the world's greatest private collection of art treasures. A chain link fencing topped by razor wire separated the site from the outside road, not as forbidding as Simmo had been expecting, with the kind of access gates and security checkpoints that could be found at any international airport or government building.

Once inside, he, like the Freeport's other clients, discovered 24-hour protected areas, CCTV cameras, biometric sensors, secure lifts, heavy metal doors, and in addition a sophisticated air-conditioning system that controlled the building's temperatures and humidity so as to conserve the stored treasures in perfect condition.

The vast warehouses were composed of endless identical corridors with locked store rooms on either side. Behind the heavy doors were metal racks on which were carefully stacked wooden cases of all shapes and sizes. They contained paintings, statues, furniture, books and other treasures deposited for safe keeping by rich collectors and investors living in New York, London, Paris or Tokyo, far from the eyes of fiscal authorities and other parties interested in their wealth. Some said they also hid works of art seized by the Nazis from Jewish families, treasures looted from archaeological sites, valuable cultural objects stolen from war torn Middle Eastern countries, and pre-Columbian artefacts smuggled out of Mesoamerica.

It was like a vast bank vault where wealth was deposited for safe keeping—commodities to be traded for a profit at a propitious moment, to protect the owners from the vagaries of currencies and the volatility of stock markets. Art had become a safe haven asset which in addition could be safely hidden from tax authorities, covetous families and ex-wives.

The rich could store anything from gold bars to rare wines, collector's cars and art treasures in the Freeport. In addition they could hire the services of experts and take advantage of specialised showrooms designed to display works for sale or organise small private events in congenial surroundings far from the prying eyes of the media.

In all more than a million valuable objects, besides countless bottles of rare wines, were stored in one of the most secure places on Earth, the most precious behind massive steel doors that had nothing to envy of the vaults of the Bank of England in the City of London.

At the reception Simmo presented himself to the hostess and five minutes later was met by a customer relations assistant, Jean-Louis Favre, who asked for his passport, account references and inventory numbers. Simmo obliged and announced he would like to inspect the objects stored on behalf of his company. A mere formality as the objects stored in the Freeport's warehouses were the property of its customers

whose only obligation was to declare the nature of the stored items, but not their value.

Simmo was led to a steel door where entry was controlled by an access code and a key. Favre punched in the code and unlocked the door, inside, the storage area was lined with metal racks on which were stacked wooden cases of various sizes. He was pointed to a narrow space not more than about 60 centimetres wide and one metre deep on which lay one small lonely packing case marked 'Fragile'.

'I'll have a storeman take it to a viewing room.'

'Good,' replied Simmo avoiding small talk. He was used to bank strong rooms and assumed the same polite distance was de rigueur in the Freeport and was expected by the personnel.

The aproned storeman carefully placed the case onto a rubber wheeled trolley and the assistant led the way back to the corridor and to a rather plain viewing room where the case was placed on a table.

'Shall I have it opened Mr Simmonds?'

He nodded.

The storeman produced a screwdriver and expertly removed six screws, then stepped back without opening the lid.

'We'll leave you now sir. If you wish you may take anything you need with you,' Favre informed him.

Simmo nodded.

'This is not a customs controlled area, by the way. Our records show Swiss VAT has been paid on this item, a 19th century facsimile, according to the declaration,' Favre said looking into the folder he was carrying.

Simmo nodded and thanked him.

'We have import and due diligence declarations on our files, the latter in good faith, these apply to persons domiciled abroad and to companies having their registered office abroad. The stated purpose is I

believe reselling the property for the company's or a third party's account.'

Simmo nodded again.

'I'm sorry to say our laws have become more complicated, but they are still much more favourable to collectors and art dealers compared to our friends across the border,' Favre said nodding in what Simmo assumed was the direction of France.

Simmo made a sign of approval and forced a smile.

'Just press on the button when you're finished,' Favre concluded pointing to a buzzer on the wall near the door.

Once the door was closed, Simmo gingerly lifted the lid of the small crate. Inside was a darkly polished wood box with a silver clasp. He took it out and opened it. Inside, laying on a red velvet lining, was an ancient very worn leather bound book. He opened it and turned the thick pages, they were full of what were evidently hand drawn images, fine images, mostly of plants, some coloured some not, certain depicted people, animals and buildings as well as what appeared to be descriptions in old Spanish and glyphs.

Simmo then opened his briefcase, removed the cash contained in the large envelope, stuffed the banknotes into the zippered side pocket, then carefully slipped the ancient book into the thick manilla envelope, put it into the briefcase, replaced the box back in the wooden crate, then pressed on the buzzer.

'Everything in order Mr Simmonds?'

'Excellent.'

'Would you like to visit the other zone now?'

Simmo was almost caught by surprise, he checked himself just in time.

'Yes, I'll do that.'

Favre led the way. Again the corridor was long, plain and brightly light. In another storage room he pointed to a larger space containing several somewhat larger packing cases, which from their form Simmo deducted contained paintings.

He made a pretence of inspecting them then indicated all was in order and it would be enough for the day.

Simmo was then led back to the reception, where after a cursory security check, his passport was returned and Favre bid him goodbye.

Simmo returned to the car and after a few moments of reflection headed back to the airport where he returned the rental car, then took a taxi to the lakeside Four Seasons Hotel situated in the downtown area of Geneva. He had no trouble getting a room, the hotel was half empty, in spite of the fine weather, the Covid crisis had frightened off the usual well-heeled tourists found in the city at that time of year.

The room set him back a packet, but it overlooked the lake and the security it offered reassured him. Once in his room the first thing he did was lock the book and cash in the room safe. He flopped onto the bed and slept for a couple of hours as the jetlag finally caught up on him.

It was four in the afternoon when he awoke and after taking a shower he headed for the nearby luxury boutiques where bought a fresh set of clothes and an additional travel bag that went with the style of his own.

Back in the room he felt better, refreshed, the lakeside air was invigorating compared to the tropical humidity of Central America. His journey seemed justified after his discoveries at the Freeport, though there were many questions. The first was the book, which even to his non-expert opinion was not a facsimile and was certainly of value, how much remained to be seen. As for the cases remaining in the Freeport he could return to examine them at a later time.

In the meantime he turned his attention to the book, examining it closer confirmed it was very old and certainly valuable, why else would have Wallace taken such trouble to lock it away in Switzerland.

Looking at his watch he decided he would take a walk. In the lobby he asked the concierge where he could find a good book store and was pointed to rue de la Confédération on the Left Bank, a fifteen minute walk away.

There, on the busy tram lined street, he found the well stocked store composed of four levels, an assistant pointed him to the history section on the second level where he selected a couple of books on the Aztec and the Maya civilisations and a history of the Conquista.

CHAPTER 3

BELIZE WAS A SMALL COUNTRY AND LIKE many Belizeans Simmo was a frequent visitor to neighbouring Guatemala and Mexico. Inevitably, over the years, he developed an interest in archaeology and by extension the Conquest of the pre-Columbian civilisations.

Though he was no expert he realised the glyphs were not the kind he was used to seeing in the local museum or at the different archaeological sites in

Belize, one of which was Altun Ha, just a few kilometres from his home outside Belize City.

He had often taken visitors to Altun Ha and was familiar with the Maya writing system that decorated the facades of many of its buildings. Although it was smaller than other sites in the country, it consisted of two main plazas surrounded by more than a dozen pyramids and residential structures. Hundreds of other buildings, still covered by the jungle, lay untouched as they had for hundreds of years waiting for archaeologists with the financial means to explore.

After comparing the illustrations in the ancient book to the photos in those he had just bought, he scratched his head disappointedly and turned his attention to the handwritten texts, part of which he recognised as old Spanish and very difficult to follow.

As he turned the pages an envelope fell to the floor. He picked it up, it was addressed to *whom it may concern*. Inside was a letter written by Wallace, it was brief, announcing that the book had been given to him in exchange for services rendered by the family from whom he had bought the land surrounding his villa, an old family descended from

English settlers that had been present in 1862, when Belize, then known as British Honduras, was declared a British crown colony.

The book had been handed down for safekeeping from generation to generation, a family heirloom. They had claimed to be descended from the English privateers who had used the coast as their base to raid the Spanish treasure fleets sailing from the New World to Spain in the early 17th century.

Over the centuries, like most families in Belize, they became part of that conflux of humanity, an extraordinary melting pot, where their English, Spanish, African and more recently Indian and Chinese ancestors, met and mingled with the descendants of the Maya, giving many that undefinable appearance.

Wallace briefly noted that after acquiring visas to the US with his help, the family had vanished into the masses of recent arrivals somewhere in the vast urban sprawl of New York City and its outlying districts.

The book, dated from 1579 according to Wallace, was written in two texts, both in the Roman alphabet, Spanish and another language, which Simmo did not recognise. In addition were the ideographic signs. It vaguely recalled a codex, however, rather than the screen-folded Mayan codices it was bound like an old but conventional book.

It was evidently not a facsimile, he had seen one of those in the Belize Museum. This book was worn, not damaged, but simply worn at the edges, by time and many hands.

He Googled 'codex' and discovered numerous such texts existed, a little more research confirmed it could be of value, and if it really was authentic, perhaps of great value. There was however a downside, it appeared there existed a number of famous forgeries to which were regularly added new 'discoveries'.

With further search and cross referencing he came to the conclusion the other language was Nahuatl, the language of the Aztecs, which

seemed strange as Belize was far from the region in Mexico where that language had been and was still spoken.

Simmo couldn't help asking himself about Wallace's intentions, he had evidently realised the book's value, perhaps not its worth in dollars and cents, but its possible historical value.

But then there was another question, that of the other cases in the Freeport warehouse, almost certainly paintings, and where they could they have come from. Wallace had not been a rich man in the sense he could have accumulated an art collection.

Who else could be interested in such treasure?

He returned to Google and came across a report on a recent Sotheby's sale of pre-Columbian art. There was the picture of a vase with the words 'type codex', it was just 12 centimetres high, and was auctioned for 100,000 euros. He continued his search, there existed many different types of codices certain of which were described as priceless.

Not only would it be difficult to sell, it would certainly be seen as a national cultural treasure by Belize or other countries that could make claims, and would require a very wealthy buyer.

Legally antiquities found in Mesoamerica should be declared to the local authorities by the finders, however the codex was not an archaeological discovery, but a possession of the deceased's family, and for many generations.

After reinspecting the manuscript, for that is what it was, a book written and illustrated by hand, he pursued his search, following the links to museums and historical libraries and learned institutions.

Soon he discovered images of the Florentine Codex at the Biblioteca Medicea Laurenziana, a world famous library in Florence, Italy, and was astonished by the remarkable similarities with the manuscript now in his possession. Then, after downloading an illustrated publication of the codex from Texas University, he spent the following couple of hours studying the extraordinary work and came to the conclusion the manuscript in his possession was either a real addendum to the work

produced by the Franciscan friar Bernardino de Sahagun or a very clever forgery.

If the Wallace codex, as he now called it in his mind, was the real thing it could be worth millions, and if he could find a buyer the proceeds would transform his now very anaemic retirement plan into one that would enable him to live in the kind of style that had eluded him during his long years in the grubby tropical backwater that now threatened to make him its prisoner.

He decided to eat in the hotel restaurant with its magnificent view over the lake, but he found it difficult to concentrate on anything but the codex he had left in the safebox of his room. As he ate different ideas raced through his mind mixed with a re-run of his visit to the Freeport. Looking out at the lake he took a breath and paused, making an effort to reorganise his thoughts, at that precise moment a large motor yacht passed in the middle distance, suddenly Sir Patrick Kennedy sprung to mind, a rich banker, who had visited Belize a couple of years earlier aboard his yacht. Amongst Kennedy's friends was a Spanish archaeologist and a Parisian fine arts dealer, an Englishman, or was he Irish?

He pulled out his phone and started to run through his contacts, he stopped at Scott Fitznorman of Asia Galleries in Paris. He looked at his watch, it was just after seven.

He called for the check and returned to his room where he called Scott Fitznorman, who to his relief replied.

'Hello Mister Fitznorman,' he commenced, preferring a formal approach to start with, 'This is Barry Simmonds of Young & Simmonds Belize Attorneys, perhaps you remember us from your visit to Belize City with Sir Patrick Kennedy, about eighteen months ago,' he hesitated, then for good measure added, 'our firm introduced Sir Patrick to Audrey Joy Grant, she's the governor of the Belize Central Bank.'

It was a bit of an exaggeration in the sense Simmo had introduced Pat Kennedy at a crowded Independence Day cocktail.

'Yes, of course Barry, I remember we met at the Radisson,' Fitznorman replied. He was a well-known international art dealer and remembering names and faces was part of his business.

Simmo was relieved though he was not naïve. 'I'm calling from Geneva on behalf of a client.'

'I see, how can I be of help.'

It wasn't the first time a lawyer called him on behalf of a real or pretended client about an object d'art.

'Are you familiar with the Florentine Codex?'

'Yes of course.'

'Good, well I won't go into details over the phone. Where can we meet?'

'Well, I'm afraid I in Spain at the moment. San Sebastian. I'm here for an ethnic art fair until the end of the week.'

'I'll be there tomorrow afternoon,' announced Simmonds, recalling San Sebastian was in the north of the country, in the Basque Country, a largish city, a few hours drive from Madrid.

'I see, I staying at Hotel de Londres y de Inglaterra, do you need a room?'

'Yes, if you could manage that for me. One other thing, this is strictly between us, you know, lawyers confidentiality.'

'You can count on me,' replied Fitznorman intrigued by Simmonds who he remembered being a rather amusing, slightly worn expatriate, rather out of place in Belize, which had struck him as a steaming and threatening backwater.

Simmo booked a seat on the early Iberia flight that left at 7:10 and arrived in Madrid two hours later. It was perfect, the four hour drive to San Sebastian meant he would arrive sometime in the early afternoon if all went well.

He passed a restless night and was awake at five and as drank his coffee he continued to compare his manuscript with the Texas University publication which described the twelve books of the

Florentine Codex. It was, however, a necessarily brief description as the original, in the Biblioteca Medicea Laurenziana was made up of three books and totalled of 3,120 pages.

Compiled between 1576 and 1577, the codex was the work of one Bernardino de Sahagun, who had arrived in Mexico in 1529. The books were transcribed from accounts of life in Mexico prior to the Conquest, recounted by different Aztec people, high ranking individuals who had witnessed the collapse of Moctezuma's empire and the Spanish conquest. In 1569 after Bernardino reorganized and corrected the different accounts, they were bound into books and sent to Madrid, where it was believed the codex was offered as a gift of Philip II of Spain to the Grand Duke of Tuscany in around 1589.

Simmo then noted the existence of another manuscript from that period, it dated from around 1580 and was kept in the collection of the Royal Academy in Madrid. Known as the Tolosa Codex, it was acquired from the Franciscan Convent of Tolosa in Navarre in 1873.

During the flight to Madrid, thanks to the books he had bought in Geneva, he swotted up on the history of the Conquista and learnt more of Bernardino who had arrived at Veracruz on the Caribbean coast at the age of 29. He lived in Mexico to what was a great age in those times, more than 90 years old, never returning to Spain.

Sahagun's work was considered to be one of the most outstanding ethnographic documents of pre-Columbian Mexico, since it provided detailed accounts of Mexican life during the 15th and 16th centuries, just before the cataclysmic collapse of the Aztec world, that brought about the destruction of its political system, and the extinction of most of its traditions and beliefs.

Beyond the chronicle of the Conquest, seen from an Aztec standpoint, it described the existence of botanical gardens and zoos in Tenochtitlan, the Aztec capital, as well as in other cities of pre-Columbian Mesoamerica. It was the only surviving account of life in Mexico, as

told by Aztecs, told just ten years after Cortes landed in Veracruz, the start of the conquest, which was ended with the death of Moctezuma II, on June 29, 1521, and fall of Tenochtitlan, in the summer of 1522, when the besieged defenders, plagued by smallpox and dysentery, starving and without fresh water, were finally forced into submission on August 13.

The Conquistadors established their new capital, now Mexico City, in 1521, on the ruins of Tenochtitlan, a city of more than 400,000 with its outlying areas, comparable to the largest European cities of that time, the capital of an empire of 15 million people.

At the time of the Conquest, the library of Tenochtitlan held thousands of written works. Tragically, the Spanish destroyed almost all of the library's codices, long scrolls folded into books, obliterating forever the Aztec traditions and beliefs in the Spanish king's determination to convert his new subjects to Christianity. Fewer than 20 codices survived.

Simmo was fascinated to learn that hyperspectral scanning of a Mayan codex held in the Bodleian Library by researchers at Oxford University had revealed unknown images hidden beneath a layer of plaster and gesso, a series of figures laid out like a comic strip.

The Codex, acquired from John Selden in the 17th century, measured five metres in length, written on deer skin, and folded like an accordion into a book.

In the 1950s, researchers scraped off a small quantity of paint, revealing a layer of images that had been painted over indicating the support had been reused. To avoid further damage to the precious document, the investigation was abandoned until new technology was developed in the form of hyperspectral imaging which revealed pictures executed with red, orange and yellow pigments. A total of 27 human figures wearing head dresses and carrying sticks or spears were identified on just one page.

It confirmed the document was a palimpsest, that is a recycled support, and what was more astonishing was the text did not match that of other early manuscripts used in Mesoamerica before the Conquest.

Further, Simmo learnt the Mayan language was neither Mixtec, Nahuatl, nor Zapotec, but a separate family, which continued to be widely spoken since the Maya resisted the Conquistadors almost two centuries, longer than the Aztecs and the Incas.

The flight was otherwise uneventful and on time and when Simmo landed in Madrid he was somewhat wiser as to the language and history of the region in which he had lived for almost three decades.

After de-planing he took the Schengen passport control line, where looking straight ahead he acted as nonchalantly as possible, he was in luck, he passed unchallenged and five minutes later he was in the arrivals hall hanging tightly onto his briefcase and the two carry-ons allowed for business class travellers. His precaution was justified considering he was carry the valuable codex as well as an unusually large sum of cash.

He headed directly for the Hertz counter where he rented a comfortable SEAT Ateca for the four hour drive to San Sebastian.

CHAPTER 4

THE ROAD TO SAN SEBASTIAN WAS A fast autopista and Madrid's international airport was soon behind him as he headed north towards the Pais Vasco under a luminous sky. Three and a half hours later the road descended from the dry plateau to the greenery of the Atlantic coast. Skirting Bilbao he continued north to San Sebastian and less than half an hour later he pulled up outside the Hotel de Londres, a fine 19th century edifice that overlooked la Concha, the magnificent beach and bay that was the splendour of Donostia, as the Basques called their city.

The Hotel de Londres y de Inglaterra was a landmark that dated back to the latter half of the 19th century when the railways opened up the Basque Country to tourism after the Spanish king, Alfonso XII, chose the city as his summer residence and set up court. His queen, Maria Christina of Austria, then built the Palacio de Miramar overlooking la Concha.

The arrival of the court soon attracted Europe's nobility and upper classes and a new form of elite tourism developed as in Biarritz which lay 40 kilometres to the north where the French Emperor Napoleon III built a palace for his Spanish wife Eugénie de Montijo.

The city became a pole of attraction during the Belle Époque making San Sebastian one of the most cosmopolitan city in Europe, visited by Queen Victoria in 1889 during her sojourn in Biarritz. Other visitors included the Prince of Wales, artists like Toulouse-Lautrec, and actors such as Orson Welles.

San Sebastian continued to prosper during World War I whilst the rest of Europe fought in the trenches. One of the victims of that terrible conflict was a well-known visitor to the city, Margaretha Geertruida

Zelle, also known as Mata Hari, who was executed in Paris in 1917 by a firing squad for allegedly spying for the Central Powers.

Less spoken about today was Generalísimo Franco, El Caudillo, who until his death in 1975 had his summer home in the city.

After checking in, Simmo called Scott Fitznorman, who invited him over to the Kursaal Congress Centre, which he explained was a short taxi ride or a 15 minutes walk away.

Simmo opted for the walk, it would clear his head after almost a full day of travelling. With a city plan in his hand to guide him, he left the hotel on the seafront promenade side. The temperature was in the mid-twenties, mild and refreshing compared to the sticky Caribbean climate he was more used to. It was relatively calm for early summer, the tourists were not in a hurry to venture too far with the Covid-19 pandemic hanging over them as the virus had almost certainly not said its last word.

Sporting his toquilla straw Panama and a brightly coloured short sleeved shirt he set off. It wasn't Simmo's first visit to Spain though he had never visited the Pais Vasco. He enjoyed his stroll, admiring the fine 19th architecture of the city, though he firmly held his briefcase under his arm, having lived in the Caribbean most of his life he was taking no chances, even if the Basque Country was considered a very law abiding region of Spain.

He couldn't miss the Kursaal, a modern glass and concrete convention centre on the other side of the Urumea, the river that runs through the centre of the city. He called Fitznorman who told him to wait at the main entrance. Five minutes later Scott appeared, a little different to Simmo's mind, perhaps it was the well cut suit he wore with a scarlet silk tie and matching shirt, dressed as a well-known art dealer should be.

Fitznorman spotted Simmonds, it wasn't too difficult, with his Panama and bright shirt, he looked more like a Central American than an

Englishman, and the briefcase tightly under one arm confirmed his impression.

‘Nice to see you again Barry,’ he said with a broad smile as though they were old friends. ‘How was the journey?’

‘Fine.’

‘No problem with the hotel?’

‘None.’

‘Excellent. Perhaps we should find a quiet spot to talk. Inside?’

‘I’d prefer not to,’ Simmo replied with a furtive glance at what he supposed were the congressistes entering and leaving the Kursaal. ‘Too many art dealers,’ he said with a weak smile, knowingly tapping the brief case with a nicotine stained finger.

‘I understand. Let’s walk across the bridge to the Parte Vieja, there’s a small bar I know, it should be quiet at this time of the day.’

They headed across the bridge, retracing Simmo’s step as he spoke of his business in Belize and Panama, without alluding to the manuscript.

Fitznorman guided him past the fine food market—its neoclassical facade and elaborate cornice built in cream coloured sandstone which was common to many of the city’s buildings, then turning into the Parte Vieja.

The crowd was rather sparse and after a couple of minutes he led Simmonds into a narrow bar. The lighting was low, and the bar stretched deep into the shadows, on one side was a series of booths set against the wall facing the bar, there the tables were separated by shoulder height partitions.

Fitznorman pointed to the bar top which was loaded with a spectacular display of tapas set out on trays and invited his guest to select a few which they carried to a booth with a couple of glasses of deep red Rioja wine.

‘It’s quiet here, mostly local people during the day, they’re a bit wary of mixing together at the moment, you know, the Covid.’

‘It’s perfect.’

‘So Barry, how can I help you?’ Fitznorman asked, thinking of pre-Columbian antiquities and certain Simmonds was not wasting his time after having travelled so far.

Simmo placed his briefcase on the table and opened it so that the flap hid its contents from the open side of the booth.

‘I’d like to know what you think of this,’ he said carefully moving the glasses and plates well to one side, then placing the manuscript on one of the paper napkins he’d spread out on the table.

Fitznorman opened the cover with great care and proceeded to turn the pages very slowly.

‘Well it’s not an incunabula,’ he said softly.

Simmo frowned.

‘That means printed before the start of the 16th century, which doesn’t mean it’s not valuable,’ he continued as though he was talking to himself. ‘Neither is it post-incunable, that is printed after 1500 and before 1520 or 1540.’

Fitznorman was suddenly aware he was talking in riddles. ‘I’m sorry Barry. It’s quite extraordinary, a codex,’ he said, ‘to be precise a manuscript, written by hand, before the introduction of the printing press.’

‘A codex.’

‘Correct, a wonderful work, priceless. Can you tell me something more about it, where it came from?’

Simmo told him it had been handed down over generations, from father to son, by an old Belize family. It had come into his hands just before the last remaining member of the family passed away, in gratitude for the help he had provided for the old man. There was little else to add, apart from his own very brief internet search.

‘Yes, the Florentine Codex, that’s it, the same thing,’ announced Fitznorman. ‘If I remember rightly there are three original books, all in the Laurentian Library in Florence.’

‘That’s right, the Biblioteca Medicea Laurenziana,’ murmured Simmo knowledgeable.

‘The work of Friar Bernardino, *The General History of New Spain*.’

‘Yes, I visited the Museum’s internet site and was redirected to the World Digital Library where a scanned copy was available, all 3,000 pages. I could only look at a few of them, but it’s true the resemblance is remarkable.

Fitznorman confirmed the General History had been executed in black ink and coloured paints on folios of paper, measuring 20 by 28 centimetres, paper that had been made and imported to Mexico from Europe. According to specialists the texts and images had been certainly carried out under the supervision of Bernardino by a number of different writers and artists.

In addition some believed the work had been hastily completed in 1580, probably so as not to miss the Flota de Indias, the annual convoy that carried goods and treasure from the New World across the Atlantic to Spain.

‘What is it worth?’ asked Simmonds not wanting to beat about the bush.

‘Worth? That’s a tough question Barry. Assuming it’s genuine, from the time of Bernardino, it’s priceless. But from a strictly financial point of view, I’d say it’s worth millions.’

Simmond’s pulse quickened.

‘Just to give you an idea, in 1994, Bill Gates bid 33 million dollars for a 72 page manuscript at a Christie’s sale in New York, the Codex Leicester. At the time it was one of the highest prices ever paid for a book. Today that would be worth more than double that price.’

Simmo emptied his glass of wine in one gulp.

‘Of course the Codex Leicester was written by Leonardo da Vinci, in the early 1500s, but in this case,’ he said laying his hand almost

reverently on the manuscript, 'with so few works dating from the early years of the Conquista, it makes this a very unique historical document.' Simmo tried to say something, but he'd lost his voice.

'So what's your plan Barry?'

'I suppose a more more detailed examination would be the next logical step,' he croaked, 'authentication.'

'Yes dating, identification and description, that is of the contents.'

'Of course,' Simmo concurred. 'But I have to insist, as I mentioned when I called you, this is totally confidential. You can imagine the claims that could be made by the Mexican or even the Spanish governments.'

'Of course. So how can I help?' asked Fitznorman batting the ball back in Simmo's court.

'Can we find an expert?'

'As a matter of fact we can, right here in San Sebastian, a good friend of Sir Patrick's by the way. She's an historian.'

'She?'

'Yes, Anna Basurko.'

Simmonds face lit up. 'Yes, I remember her,' he said, how could he forget the attractive archaeologist, 'she was with Sir Patrick in Belize.'

Scott Fitznorman called his assistant at the Kursaal to announce he would not be back and cancelled his evening appointment, called a taxi and accompanied Simmo back to the Hotel de Londres. It wasn't worth taking the least risk with Simmo and his precious charge, especially as he was very visible, a tourist wearing his Panama and flowered shirt.

CHAPTER 5

IT WAS STILL EARLY IN THE EVENING when Anna Basurko arrived at the hotel, Spaniards ate very late. She remembered the Englishman for his eccentric appearance, he looked like Graham Greene's vacuum cleaner salesman, or was it John Le Carré's tailor, a caricature, as though he had just stepped out of the screen adaption of the former's novel.

Simmo hadn't been mistaken, she was very attractive. They'd briefly met the previous year, at a reception onboard Sir Patrick's yacht, *Las Indias*, in Belize.

It was a fine evening and Scott invited them to the Mata Hari suit for privacy and drinks. He always booked the seventh floor suite during the Feria de Arte y Antigüedades art salon week. It was called El Septimo Cielo for its magnificent suits with their broad private terraces overlooking La Concha and across the bay to Santa Clara Island.

Scott had outlined to Anna the reason for their meeting, but had avoided going into the details of the 'work' to avoid attracting unwanted attention, one could never be too careful with the Salon at the Kursaal in full swing, where millions were at stake, and eavesdropping was not unknown.

After the small talk and briefing he saw Anna was impatient to see the 'work'. They went inside to the reception room of his suite where the blinds were drawn offering shade from the bright sunlight.

Simmo placed his brief case on the low table and carefully took out the manuscript now protected in a hotel laundry bag, unwrapped it and placed it before Anna's expert eye.

Somehow it was not what she had expected. After a few moments of hesitation, puzzlement, she cautiously inspected the cover, passing her fine manicured fingers over the worn leather, almost as if she was communicating with the ancient book, she then opened it with the greatest of care, turning the first few pages, pausing at the illustrations.

‘Extraordinary,’ she whispered, her voice dry. ‘Bernardino de Sahagun, impossible.’

She sat back on the sofa with a look of disbelief on her face.

Anna was an archaeologist, her field was underwater research, specialised in the period of Spain’s New World Empire, where since the conquest more than one thousand vessels had been lost along the Caribbean, Atlantic and Pacific coasts, galleons, treasure ships and merchant ships of all descriptions.

Her work involved research in Spain’s vast historical archives, stored in Madrid and Seville, where millions of documents meticulously recorded the history of the vast colonial empire that had stretched westwards across the Atlantic to New Spain and beyond the Pacific to the Philippines.

Anna’s research had regularly brought her to Seville, to the Archivo General de Indias—the largest collection of historical documents relating to the Spanish Empire. The 16th century building housed 80 million pages of documents and maps, nine kilometres of shelves, dating from the 16th, 17th and 18th centuries, an incredibly complete history of the New World under Spanish rule.

Spanish merchants in the Consulado de cargadores, in Seville, had the monopoly of trade with the colonies, and merchants, acting on behalf of foreign traders, exported their goods on the Flota de Indias to the New World. Seville, on the rio Guadalquivir, in Andalusia, was the exclusive point of departure and return for the fleets of galleons, urcas and caravels that carried all trade with the New World.

In addition more remarkably meticulous records were kept in the

Archivo Historico Nacional and the Naval Museum in Madrid as well as in other archives in Seville and Valladolid, detailing the movements of all vessels, their cargoes, crews and passengers. The records were an extraordinary source of information, though many things were dissimulated by those who sought to escape taxes on smuggled treasure or prevent secrets from falling into their enemies hands.

Thanks to these archives, Anna had studied the history of more than 1,000 galleons and merchant ships lost along the coast of New Granada, a vast territory from New Spain south to what is today's Colombia, Venezuela and Panama.

She was an expert, she had spent more hours than she cared to remember pouring over countless documents, letters, manuscripts and printed books, from the earliest voyages of Columbus, of Magellan, and the

Conquistadors—Cortes and Pizarro, and finally to the last throes of empire which ended in the Spanish-American War when the curtain fell on four centuries of exploration, conquest, glory, riches, Christianisation, war, slavery, torture and death.

The question that had always troubled Anna was the story of the peoples who fell under the Conquistador's swords, how little of their history had survived, there was of course the impressive stone vestiges in the form of pyramids, temples, palaces, ball courts, plazas and stelae, but of the libraries that told the story of the Aztecs, Mayas and Incas and their beliefs, their history, culture and science, almost nothing was left.

Simmo spoke Spanish fluently, but was not familiar with the flowery handwriting, the literary style and terms of the 16th century text. Anna on the other hand understood the manuscript perfectly which at first glance appeared to principally concern medicinal herbs and plants and their utilisation.

'Firstly, subject to laboratory tests, the manuscript appears to be authentic,' she announced. 'Secondly it's a herbal apothecary, probably

Aztec, compiled by Franciscan monks, possibly Bernardino de Sahagun and his assistants. As you can see it's written in three parallel texts, Spanish, romanised Nahuatl and traditional Aztec glyphs, that said the illustrations of the various plants seem to be typical of the style used during that period in Europe.'

The two men nodded and eagerly waiting for her to continue.

'It's an incredibly rare document which will excite a lot of attention and...', she searched for a word, 'covetousness, you know ownership claims. By the way Barry, are you the owner?'

'Yes,' he replied.

'I'm sorry to say this, but have you documentary proof?'

'Yes,' he lied, a little too quickly.

'What do you plan to do with it?'

'Find a buyer.'

She looked at the manuscript pensively, to her mind it was part of Spanish history, it would certainly be claimed by Mexico, but like other codices it could end up in Florence, Berlin or wherever, bought by the highest bidder.

That it belonged to Simmonds, Anna wasn't convinced, but that was not her problem, at least for the moment.

It would require a considerable amount of work to authenticate the codex, date it, translate it, settle legal claims, and find a home for it. First it would require an agreement with Simmonds and no doubt a financial arrangement. Perhaps with Pat Kennedy or his friends the Clancys.

But the most important would be confidentiality, secrecy, any leak to the media would create an avalanche of interest with a flurry of claims and counter claims, the usual controversies from academia and the international political world, not forgetting Interpol, Europol and national cultural authorities with accusations related to the trafficking of

archaeological works, not forgetting controversial questions from the world of art and culture on the import and export of treasures and historical artefacts.

Most urgent was the need to convince Simmonds of the urgency of putting the codex into safe keeping, both from the material and security points of view.

‘There’ll be no problem finding a buyer, but you’ll have to be very careful with such a valuable work of art.’

‘How much do you think it’s worth?’

‘I’m not an expert,’ she said looking at Scott, ‘but it could be millions, many millions.’

Simmo frowned. ‘What about Sir Patrick?’

‘I’ll speak to him tomorrow,’ she promptly replied. ‘If I’m not mistaken he should be in London at the moment, but there’s the problem of the quarantine,’ she added with a smile. ‘What are your plans Barry?’

He shrugged, for the millions they were talking about he would make the time to meet Kennedy. ‘Perhaps you could fix a meeting with Sir Patrick, I do believe he’s a collector.’

She looked at her watch. ‘I’ll call him tonight and we can meet first thing tomorrow morning if you like. First, I’d like to involve our security firm, an object that’s worth perhaps tens of millions shouldn’t be lying around in a hotel room.’

There was a moment’s hesitation. Then to her relief, he nodded in agreement.

‘We can manage everything, if you agree Barry,’ said Scott, ‘but perhaps you as a lawyer should draw up an agreement.’

Simmo didn’t need convincing, he realised with Anna, Fitznorman and their friends there would be less risk than dealing with people he’d never met and knew nothing of. In his business he knew there were many more crooks around than honest people would ever believe.

‘I have a very good wall safe here in the suite, in my business we need that kind of a facility, it would be better here than in your room, like that you won’t have to take it into the shower with you,’ Scott said with a convincing smile. ‘I’ll show it to you.’

He led Simmonds into the suite’s work space which was equipped with a computer, printer and xerox machine and showed him the large safe hidden behind a wall panel.

‘Good, I’ll draft an agreement,’ said Simmonds.

Scott indicated an elegant late 19th century writing desk where a hotel folder containing a writing pad lay.

Twenty minutes later the three of them signed a brief hand written agreement couched in concise legal terms as to their arrangement, which all three signed. Scott ran two copies off on the xerox, handed Simmo the original, then locked the codex in the safe.

Anna excused herself promising to be back at eight thirty for breakfast in the suite with news from Sir Patrick or Liam Clancy.

Scott then invited Barry to join him on the terrace where they could admire the spectacular sunset across the bay and ordered a light evening meal, a plate of *jamon iberico* and a mixed salad with a bottle of Txakoli, a sparkling dry white wine from the vineyards to the west of Getaria, a small town a few kilometres from San Sebastian.

It was eleven when Barry returned to his room slightly light headed after the wine, but above all the exhilaration at the promise of wealth, the kind that years of work in Belize had escaped him. Perhaps now he could enjoy the kind of life that certain of those he had seen stashing their wealth in the Caribbean enjoyed.

Anna hurried back to her apartment in the Area Romantica, on the corner of Elcano and Peñaflorida, overlooking Gipuzkoa Gardens, a fifteen minute walk from the Hotel de Londres. There she called Pat Kennedy, who was in London, and briefed him on the codex. He immediately agreed to fly down to San Sebastian Airport near to Irun as

soon as he finished his appointment in London the following morning, accompanied by George Pyke and one of his men to take care of the security question.

CHAPTER 6

IT WAS ALMOST MIDDAY WHEN PAT, accompanied by George Pyke and his man, boarded Pat's Gulfstream ready to take off at London's City Airport. The terminal building was eerily empty at a time of day when it should normally have been packed with excited Londoners heading for Ibiza. The traffic was down 90%, which meant there were no delays, a situation that arranged Pat Kennedy who had seen traffic from what was once an almost private airport explode, transforming it into a bus station for mostly younger travellers heading for a rave in Palma de Mallorca or Ibiza.

A couple of hours later the Gulfstream landed at San Sebastian's small airport on the banks of the Bidassoa, the river that separated Spain from France. After disembarking they were greeted by a funereal silence, the terminal was even quieter than London and barely five minutes after the passport formalities they exited arrivals where Anna warmly greeted Pat and his friends.

They were just 18 kilometres from San Sebastian's La Concha area, just enough time for Anna to fill Pat in on the story of the manuscript.

*

Sir Patrick Kennedy, was not only head of INI Hong Kong, an international banking giant, he was also a generous patron of the arts, a collector with a real interest in history and archaeology. Two years earlier he had backed Anna's excavation of a Spanish galleon that had sunk off the Caribbean coast of Colombia at the beginning of the 18th century, salvaging its extraordinary cargo, now known as the Treasure

of the Espiritu Santo, and housed in a museum in Cartagena de Indias built by his bank.

Anna Basurko through her research had located the site of the wreck and Pat Kennedy had provided the scientific and logistical backup along with the Colombian government during the operations.

Towards the end of the underwater excavations and the salvage of the treasure, the divers discovered a cache of rare pre-Columbian artefacts that had been on their way to Spain aboard the *Espiritu Santo*, artefacts that had their origin in the north, either in the Mayan or Aztec regions of Central America. This brought Pat Kennedy and Anna to Honduras and Belize, accompanied by Scott Fitznorman and the renowned French archaeologist René Veil who identified the objects as Mayan, similar to discoveries already made in what is now Belize.

Pat's interest in Mesoamerican civilisations had grown following a strange encounter with Ken Hisikawa in Nicaragua a few years earlier. They had become good friends, and Ken, a professor of archaeology at Colombia University in New York, had subsequently invited Pat to join him on several expeditions in Meso and South America.

Ken had taught Pat how numerous like civilisations had evolved over a period of nearly 3,000 years, rising and falling, in the vast region that now lay between Texas and the Yucatan Peninsula and the Guatemalan Lowlands. Amongst them were the Aztecs and their predecessors to the north, and the Maya to the south.

The Aztecs, or Mexica as they called themselves, were a Nahuatl people, whose powerful empire emerged in Central Mexico, and who dominated the peoples around them at the time the Cortes and his conquistadors disembarked on the Caribbean coast at the beginning of the 16th century.

They had originated in the semi-arid region of Northern Mexico, one of the many semi-nomadic tribes that had long inhabited that region. In the 14th century they migrated south and occupied the fertile Valley of

Mexico, where they were seen as *Chichimecs*, or barbarians, by the already advanced peoples established in their cities along the valley.

There the Aztecs built their own city, Tenochtitlan, on the wetlands surrounding Lake Texcoco, and adopted the culture of the pre-existing peoples, which included a writing system developed over the centuries, used by other peoples of Central Mexico.

‘Tell me Barry, who is the legal owner of the codex,’ asked Pat Kennedy.

‘A Cayman Island company, Cavendish Holdings.’

Simmo, after being caught out by Anna’s question, had not wasted his time during the night, setting up a cascade of screen companies, firstly in Belize, then Panama and finally the Cayman Islands, covering the trail of the codex in a series of transactions that effectively obscured its origin.

Pat Kennedy needed little convincing, the codex was undoubtedly a sensational discovery. He agreed to advance one million dollars, deposited in the Cayman Island account indicated by Simmo, followed by 50% of the final valuation. The confidential agreement between Cavendish Holdings and a company named by Kennedy included a hold harmless clause that would protect Simmonds from claims that could arise relating to the origin and ownership of codex and the sums paid to him by Kennedy.

Simmonds was a lawyer and protecting the ownership of assets, offshore companies and bank accounts, was his trade. With near on 30 years experience in the Caribbean under his belt he knew all the tricks of the business. At the same time Pat Kennedy was no slouch in offshore transactions, his bank was built around such business and he respected an old fox like Simmonds. He had his own lawyer, James Herring, who he could count on to protect his interests in any court of law.

The only thing that puzzled Pat was Simmond’s apparent evident need for cash, after all a long career in Belize as a lawyer should have

assured him of a comfortable retirement. Little did he know of Simmo's difficulties in paying for the villa he had bought on the Spanish Island of Ibiza the previous year, before the Covid pandemic struck, and the disaster it presaged for his plans following his disastrous foray into real estate development.

CHAPTER 7

THE TRUTH WAS BARRY SIMMONDS had spent his life setting up conduits for his clients dirty money, and dirty it was, the fruit of crime and corruption. He'd built a cast iron circuit of conduits, managed from Belize, into which dirty money flowed, was washed whiter than white via a cascade of Caribbean banks, channelled into real estate, sold to investors, and the proceeds wired to London via the major banks and legitimately reinvested in prime property.

It wasn't his money, he was in a manner of speaking a jobber, but now he was tired and wanted out, the trouble was after his partner Gordon Young retired to England, he'd got in too deep besides over the years his clientele had changed, at the outset they were British tax dodgers of various ilks, then thanks to Wallace, Russians, middlemen acting on behalf of a coterie of government officials, corrupt politicians, crooked businessmen and their helpers.

At the other end of the circuit with the connivance of British politicians and bankers, the City of London rolled out a red carpet to welcome a clique of thieving oligarchs fat from their feast on the carcase Soviet Union.

They appeared in all disguises, from oligarchs who sponsored English league football clubs with the money looted from state owned enterprises, stolen from the people of the USSR, to art loving billionaires with links to organized crime, who by stealth insinuated their way into British society, buying politicians, their parties, respected institutions and even the governing bodies of venerable universities.

In spite of Theresa May telling the House of Commons, 'There is no place for these people, or their money, in our country...those who seek

to do us harm, my message is simple: you are not welcome here,' Russians and former Soviet citizens continued to flock to London, stash their money in British banks and invest in businesses via by devious routes dreamt up by lawyers like Barry Simmonds.

Simmo knew too much, but how was he to get out? Like the proverbial physician he never took to time to care for himself, *Medice, cura te ipsum*. Essentially honest, but there was a streak of naivety or was it the kind of fatality that affected those who overstayed their welcome in Belize?

Sir Patrick Kennedy was a top A-List banker, one of those people who enjoyed privileges beyond those of transient politicians, diplomats and ambassadors, he enjoyed the kind of privileges enjoyed by many heads of states much larger than Belize, a country he could have bought up lock stock and barrel, if he was crazy enough to do so. Tens, even hundreds of thousands depended directly on his decisions, millions indirectly.

The wind turned when Britain's political classes finally woke up to the realisation that the City of London had become a convenient money laundering hub and prime property a vehicle to conceal the gains derived from crime and corruption. Liberalism was an admirable quality, but when it left the door open to kleptocrats and ruthless oligarchs in the guise of investors and philanthropists, agents of the Kremlin's authoritarian methods, it was not long before clear sighted men launched a cry of alarm. With so much Russian money in the City, leaders awoke to the realisation that the Kremlin's men were in a position of force to influence the country's political, cultural and educational institutions.

Simmo didn't work with those members of the British establishment, who filled their pockets preening and kowtowing to rich and powerful Russians close to the Kremlin, quaffing their vodka and caviar at cocktail parties in their extravagant homes in Knightsbridge or receptions at the Russian Embassy in Kensington Gardens.

His work was with a different tier, those that oiled and greased the machine of the Russian oligarchy, the agents, doers and bag carriers, who gleaned the crumb's that fell from the tables of their rich masters.

Belize was an offshore backwater, where for anything from 700 dollars a law firm like Simmonds & Young would set a company and a bank account in an hour for any unsavoury would be oligarch.

In a sense Simmo had, indirectly, become a de facto agent of the Russian oligarchy, not that any of the real oligarchs had ever heard of him.

His business with Wallace had made him careless, it was easy money, too easy, causing him to point his better, though more demanding, well-heeled clients towards a more successful colleague amongst the army of willing lawyers, solicitors and estate agents in the City of London or one of the UK's more reputable offshore financial tax havens.

CHAPTER 8

HISTORICALLY SPEAKING BELIZE WAS a dreary backwater, a small, not very rich country, about the size of Vermont, 23,000 km², with a total population of 400,000—about that of a medium sized European or US city.

The former British colony lay between Mexico, its very large neighbour to the north, and smaller though more threatening Guatemala on its eastern and southern borders. Guatemala's historical claim to more than one half of Belize's territory, the southern half, hung like the Sword of Damocles over a region covered by dense jungle and rainforest, even though much of the precious hardwood had been poached by illegal loggers, who left behind them a dense secondary forest, much of it impenetrable swamplands.

To the north, much of the arable land, not occupied by subsistence farmers, had been transformed into sugarcane, banana and citrus fruit plantations operated by large foreign owned agribusiness corporations.

Little was left of the rich mahogany forests that had in the not too distant past covered the entire country once known as British Honduras.

Though things had improved, more than 40% of the population still lived below the poverty line and as a consequence, to the dismay of expatriates like Barry Simmonds, the country had one of the highest crime rates in the world with a growing number of their community becoming victims of violence, home invasion, fraud and extortion.

Corruption and nepotism was rampant at all levels of Belizean society, from vote buying to police bribery and real estate scams.

The Covid-19 pandemic had tipped the economy into an unprecedented recession as tourism all but collapsed setting all the warning lights flashing.

For the moment the Belize dollar was pegged in a narrow, though widening, band to the US dollar, but as the government's debt exploded the likelihood of a sharp disconnection and a calamitous devaluation would spell disaster for Barry. The time to get out had passed, it was already too late to cash in on the nice property he owned between Belize City and the

Altun Ha Maya site, which if things continued would be worthless. A bachelor, he had lived in the villa until his latest girl friend, a fiery criolla, had taken off to join her family in New York three years earlier, he had paid her one-way ticket after he'd found her in bed with his driver. The house was too big and he'd taken to spending most of his time in the flat above his law firm's office in the centre of Belize City. That was when he wasn't in Ambergris, where, until recently, he had been looking after his business plans in the tourist resort known as 'La Isla Bonita' very much in vogue near the Mexican border.

Life had become complicated since his partner Gordon Young had retired. Theirs had been a good business, but now he was alone and had lost interest in the firm. His attempts to find a buyer had only met with frustration after a well-placed government official, Wilfred Thompson, proposed his son as a new partner with a buy-in offer well below what Simmo had been hoping for.

Simmo had joined the firm as a young solicitor fresh out Kings College in London. The opening in Belize had seemed like an exciting opportunity at a time when the former colony was a newly independent nation and about to enact its International Business Companies Act. Things started looking up when in 1996 the government introduced the International Banking Act, and he became a junior partner in the firm.

The law firm had been founded by Young who on retirement ceded the partnership to Simmonds against an annuity which came to an end when the old man passed away in Brighton.

Barry's plans became unstuck when Thompson cast a shadow over his project and the buy-in stalled. He had planned to sell his property, the proceeds of which together with the buy-in and the income he expected from a real estate investment at Ambergris, should have enabled him to retire to Ibiza where he could enjoy a new and carefree life.

Now with the million from Pat Kennedy and the prospect of much more to come, things were beginning to look a lot better and he could accept the offer from Wilfred Thompson.

Later that afternoon Simmo received confirmation of the payment to his bank account in Panama City and the codex was handed over to Pat Kennedy. He wished his friends goodbye and descended to the hotel garage. As he searched in his pocket for the car keys he found that of the safe box in Panama, he smiled to himself, thought for a moment, then dropped it into a drainage grating behind the car. In a few hours he would be on his way home via Cancun in Mexico.

Pat then invited Anna, Scott and George Pyke, to dinner, leaving George's man in the suite to watch over the safe, and headed for a small restaurant overlooking the old port. There at a pavement table they watched the evening crowd as they discussed their plans.

Pat confided the task of translation to Anna, who was forced to admit her knowledge of medicinal herbs and plants and their utilisation was extremely limited. He reassured her in the knowledge Lifegen, one of the many companies he controlled, would assist her. Lifegen was based in Sophia Antipolis, a science pole, situated in Provence, between Nice and Cannes in the South of France.

It was headed by Michel Morel and Jean-Yves Amiel whose research team counted different specialists in pharmacology and herbs. They could provide Anna with the assistance necessary for the identification of the plants described in the codex, especially those having a specific

scientific interest linked to LifeGen's work in the field of gerontology and the biological aspects of ageing.

For the moment he suggested Anna break the work into parts, dividing it amongst specialised translators to accelerate the process and keep the identity of the codex secret.

As for the question of security George Pyke proposed the codex be stored at a secure site, the Geneva Freeport. Thus, unknown to them, the codex would make a return journey to Switzerland and the safety of the bonded warehouse.

The Freeport was a reflex for those wishing to hide or put art works and cultural treasures into safekeeping, a reference in secure storage, founded by the Swiss government in 1854.

They agreed Pat would drop Anna and George Pyke off in Geneva the next morning with the codex where they could make the necessary arrangements whilst he continued to London where he had an urgent meeting with Liam Clancy to discuss the growing crisis in Hong Kong.

George and his man accompanied by Anna would deposit the codex at the Freeport, after which she would organise a meeting at the Fine Arts Experts Institute to undertake the work needed to determine its authenticity using radiocarbon dating, infrared reflectography and other techniques. At the same time effecting photographic scans for historical identification, comparative analysis and for her translation work.

CHAPTER 9

NEARLY A MONTH PASSED BEFORE ANNA received the preliminary report on the codex from the Fine Arts Experts Institute, an independent organisation, one of the world's first private scientific centres dedicated to the expertise of artworks and cultural objects, and situated inside the Freeport's zone. Its work covered the scientific authentication of paintings, sculptures, ceramics and other historical works using the most modern scientific techniques.

Anna reported to Pat Kennedy by video conference informing him of the report's conclusions, which amongst many other things indicated the paper on which the codex was written was of European manufacturer and the radiocarbon dating indicated a date between 1570 and 1590, which corresponded to the period during which Friar Bernardino was alive and active. The cover of the codex was made from calfskin and dated from the same period.

Microscopic examination showed quill pens had been used for the execution of the texts and drawings, as for the ink it was analysed using polarized light microscopy which indicated it was composed of iron, sulphur, potassium, calcium and carbon with traces of other substances. The blue, white, red-brown and green paints of the manuscript were analysed using different techniques including scanning electron microscopy. The blue paint was composed of ground azurite with traces of copper oxide cuprite. The white paint was a mixture of egg white and calcium carbonate, whilst the green was composed of copper and copper-chlorine resinate as well as atacamite or other copper-chlorine compounds. The red-browns were red ochre composed of hematite and iron sulphide.

‘So what does all that mean,’ Pat asked.

‘Basically it was produced in Mexico at the time of Bernardino, which means it’s authentic, the paper, inks and pigments are very close to those used in the Florentine Codex, which points to it being produced by the same Franciscans.’

‘Is it part of Bernardino’s work?’

‘That I can’t say. Perhaps it was conceived as an addendum, an apothecary’s herbal pharmacopoeia of plants and cures known to the Aztecs, who knows?’

‘What about its contents?’

‘Jean-Yves’s team at Lifegen is still working on that, but from what he tells me his people have identified many of the plants.’

‘And the translation?’

‘I’ve got almost all the 16th century Spanish text converted to modern Spanish and the English version will be ready next week. The Nahuatl is going to take a little longer.’

‘Great Anna, good work. I’ll be over to Paris next week, if you can meet me there we can get together with Scott and Padraig.’

‘Yes, I’ll have finalised the initial commentaries by then.’

‘Excellent.’

CHAPTER 10

BARRY HAD INVESTED A GOOD PART of his pension fund in a luxury golf complex and beachfront condominium up the coast on the San Pedro Peninsula at Ambergris Caye. He together with a local real estate developer had set up an IBC with the backing of a group of Russian investors represented by Igor Vishnevsky, a former banker, who had been introduced to him by Wallace.

Tourism had been riding the crest of a wave, it seemed as if nothing could go wrong. Encouraged by Wallace, Simmo took the plunge, getting in up front, using his pension fund and a loan from a local bank to buy the land that came with a magnificent beach of white coral sand half a kilometre from the barrier reef, the longest in the Western Hemisphere and the second longest in the world, obtain planning permission and set about building access roads and connecting the site with utilities and services.

The brochure described the 70 hectare golf course covered by a soft and smooth carpet of Bermuda grass surrounded by a pleasant tropical environment, a splendid club house and restaurant complex. Adjacent to the golf course a dozen architect designed three stories condos were planned, each consisting of eight to ten units with private balconies, high-end appliances, granite countertops, floor to ceiling windows with beachfront views of the Caribbean and San Pedro to one side and the golf course to the other, each complete with a beachfront pool.

The promotional brochure promised investors first class returns after insurance and management fees.

Well, that was before the pandemic.

Overnight the project went belly-up, leaving the clubhouse foundations and the first condos half built alongside the now overgrown golf course.

Not only had the flow of tourists stalled, sales dried up, construction ground to a halt, the bank pulled its loans and the investors wanted their money back, quick.

To make matters worse Wallace unexpectedly died and Simmo was left holding the baby. Before his eyes his retirement plan fell to pieces and the dream of a new life in his villa on Ibiza suddenly seemed very far away.

Unknown to Barry, the Russian investors represented by Igor Vishnevsky, included a top Kremlin official, Oleg Sedov, a member of the state security apparatus, which through organisations like the GRU and the FSB, used criminal networks as instruments of intelligence activity and political influence.

Now, Sedov was not only very unhappy to lose his money, he was furious at being caught up in a financial scandal in that Caribbean backwater, one that could be used to embarrass the Kremlin, at a moment when it was trying to shore up its friends in the region, especially Maduro's shaky regime in Venezuela.

Simmo, not entirely unwittingly, had become a part of the Russian laundromat that financed a web of politically subversive operations via its offshore conduits. He had become the victim of his own cupidity which had blinded him to the risks he would have once avoided.

That web reached out into the heart of the British establishment. The rot had eaten into government and parliamentary circles in London, where the members register of interest, showed several lords with links to Russian businesses. One of the lords had even served on the board of a Russian defence conglomerate, Sistema, in which, according the register of interests, he was a shareholder. The strange lord had never hidden his Russian links after he had developed a close relationship with the Russian oligarch Oleg Deripaska and his company Rusal, the

world's largest producer of aluminium, on whose yacht he had been seen.

A lawyer like Barry Simmonds could and had set up firms at Companies House in London with service providers in Belize designated as managers according to official documents. Thus, with a string of bank accounts in London and the Caribbean, large amounts of cash could be hidden to invest in bricks and mortar assets or to finance illegal activities, not forgetting financing Moscow's dirty tricks wherever the Kremlin pleased.

Britain boasted a tradition of evenhandedness and the rule of law. But its politicians and professionals were the willing servant of Mammon, including lawyers and accountants, not forgetting the establishment and its old boy clubs. Banks and regulatory authorities paid little heed to the goings on, leading politicians had their snouts in the trough, whilst journalists and whistleblowers were kept at bay by libel laws and much more vicious threats, as witnessed by the fate of Julian Assange who had spent years in his virtual prison.

It was a system exploited to the hilt by the Kremlin and its agencies which hired former UK diplomats, politicians, and intelligence officers to lobby on their behalf.

Whistleblowers were not the only ones to be targeted, there were also dissidents like the oligarch Boris Berezovsky, who decamped to London in 2000, setting up his base in Mayfair with the objective of ousting Putin, vilified by the Kremlin as a second Trotsky.

Berezovsky paid the price. He was found hanged in bizarre circumstances, in the bathroom of his home in Berkshire, a crime camouflaged as suicide by complaisant British authorities. His friend Nikolai Glushkov was found strangled in equally strange circumstances at his home in New Malden. And they were not the only ones to fall foul of the Kremlin's killers.

Be that as it may, London was the residence of predilection for both dissidents and Kremlin cronies, where they could hide their wealth and enjoy gentlemen's lives in relative safety.

CHAPTER 11

UNKNOWN TO SIMMO, HE HAD BEEN followed to Panama, there he had been seen boarding the flight to Madrid. At first he had been lost, then, 24 hours later, his pursuers picked up his trail again.

It took some time, cross referencing information, before his car rental turned up, but what he did over the following 48 hours was a blank. Spain was a big place, normally thronging with millions of tourists. Luckily, thanks to the pandemic, hotel occupation rates had fallen 70%, which made the task of finding him a little easier and the rental was traced to San Sebastian. A speeding ticket had been forwarded to the rental company by the local police after Simmo was clocked at over 60 km/h in the downtown area of the city after he left Kennedy and his friends for his return flight from Madrid.

From there it was easy, after checking guest records at all the hotels, registered for payment of tourist tax, he was traced to the Hotel de Londres, where he had spent two nights in one of their most expensive rooms.

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Wallace, having no legal training, was a middleman. On the one side he had his Russian friends with their links to the Caribbean and South America, on the other was Simmonds, who undertook the legal formalities setting up offshore companies and bank accounts with links into mainstream banking in the City of London and its offshore bases.

One of those offshore banks was Malcolm Smeaton's Anglo-Dutch Commonwealth Bank, a successful private bank that catered for high-

network clients, most of whom sought the secrecy afforded by such banks specialized in total discretion, few questions, the kind of legendary service once offered by tight-lipped Swiss banks.

Smeaton's Caribbean based bank had struggled in the immediate aftermath of the 2008 financial crisis and was bailed out when Francis Wang a Chinese businessman appeared and saved it from collapse. Then when Wang's business interests in Venezuela turned sour, Pat Kennedy stepped in and snapped up his share in the bank. Business picked up again as Pat recentered the bank's business on the growing number of high-networth individuals. Inequality in the post financial crisis decade exploded especially after Donald Trump was elected and as Big Tech surfed a new wave.

It was Wallace who had introduced Simmo to the Ambergis development, the idea of a politically connected Belize promoter. Financially it was a sound investment, in spite of the fat kickbacks.

In nearby Mexico, Cancun had become very popular with Russian tourists after Aeroflot opened a service of direct flights from Moscow. It was an attractive alternative to Cuba for Muscovites who had grown tired of Havana's spartan comforts.

It was like that Igor Vishnevsky, a former high level executive of VTB, a state owned Russian Bank, arrived in Cancun, where he set about establishing a conduit to hide money defrauded from commodity exporters, Russia's largest mining and metallurgical companies. It was not long before he developed an interest in nearby Belize, a friendly offshore platform where he could channel money via an easy to set up International Business Company (IBC), described by Arkady Demitriev's friend Gordon Wallace as 'one of the most effective corporations, a tool used by individuals and corporations around the world to plan their taxes and manage assets'.

Russian diplomatic interests in Belize were represented by Mexico, and Demitriev, a GRU agent based in Cancun, coordinated certain of

Moscow's covert operations in the region and in particular those relating to British and former British Territories.

One of Demitriev's tasks was to channel funds through Belize to finance the next phase of the Brexit disinformation campaign in London, assisted by Wallace, who managed various shell companies and their bank accounts set up for that purpose in a number of Caribbean offshore tax havens.

More recently the Russians were backing anti-vaxer groups and conspirationalists in their war to undermine political and social cohesion in their geopolitical war against Western democracies to gain strategic goals for the Kremlin's authoritarian occupant.

It had been a good business for Wallace, a long-time fellow traveller, who had led a very comfortably life style thanks to commissions he deducted from the accounts he managed for the various parties, which he deftly moved through a cascade of Caribbean banks.

Wallace had another lucrative sideline, golden passports, specifically Dominican. The Commonwealth of Dominica, not to be confused with the Dominican Republic, was an island state situated between the French Caribbean islands of Martinique and Guadalupe. It was for that reason Demitriev had introduced Vishnevsky to Wallace, with the Russian agreeing to invest in the Ambergris project, in exchange for a Dominican passports for himself and his friends, and setting aside a beachfront unit for the Dominican politico who would facilitate the procedure.

Wallace had used a classic money laundering arrangement for Oleg Sedov's funds which were transferred by Vishnevsky from a Cyprus bank via Malcolm Smeaton's Anglo-Dutch Commonwealth Bank on behalf of a British Virgin Islands company set up by Simmonds law firm.

Everything went smoothly until tourist arrivals suddenly came to a halt and sales dried up before he had time to realise what was happening. No one could have foreseen the pandemic, especially in

laid-back Belize, everyone was caught in the same trap, including Wallace and his friends, whose scheme began to unravel faster than they could think. Sedov and his pals wanted their money back, but Wallace and his local friends stalled, it wasn't so easy, and in any case they were in too deep.

The Russians were not about to be screwed by a bunch of pot smoking Rastas, they wanted the names of the banks, account numbers and codes. Unfortunately Demitriev's partners in crime, Mexican gangsters, had used heavy handed methods to persuade Wallace to hand over the details, waterboarding him in the pool at his villa, drowning him in the process.

It was very bad news for Demitriev, on top of that Vishnevsky became threatening, one because his money that was not his had disappeared and two the golden passports were not forthcoming.

Sedov had no choice but to deal with the problems, he couldn't have his operations compromised by Vishnevsky and ordered Demitriev to clean up the mess.

The first was Simmonds, who he'd learnt was charged with looking after Wallace's estate, he would have to be dealt with, though not before he explained what he had been doing or hiding in Europe.

CHAPTER 12

BACK IN BELIZE SIMMO LOOKED ON the Mayan archaeological vestiges with renewed interest as he went about the preparations for his retirement to Ibiza with renewed enthusiasm.

The following weekend he drove to a Mayan site deep in the Chiquibul Forest, 200 kilometres to the south-west of Belize City and close to the border with Guatemala. It was the most important archaeological site in Belize, Caracol, the ruins of a vast city discovered in the 1937, once home to an estimated 140,000 people, larger than Belize City itself, covering almost 180 square kilometres, abandoned around AD900, much of it now shrouded by dense rainforest and inhabited by wild animals.

It was incredible, more than 35,000 structures had been identified, the most remarkable being the Canna, a pyramid, the tallest man-made building in Belize, rising 43 metres above the summits of the forest, with the main plaza surrounded by the remains of temples, palaces, ball courts and an astronomical observatory.

As Simmo drove back to Belize that evening his mind wandered, pondering the Maya civilisation before the Conquest and the destruction of its history. Soon he would be retiring to Ibiza and he made up his mind to visit the Museo de America in Madrid where he could see the Maya codices before taking off for the Mediterranean island.

The museum was said to hold the finest collection of pre-Columbian American art and artefacts in Europe, a unique exhibition of objects brought to Spain at the time of the Conquest, and during the centuries

when Spain ruled one of the world's greatest overseas colonial empire ever.

One of its treasures was the Madrid Codex, rediscovered in Spain in the middle of the 19th century.

Its discovery was also shrouded in mystery. It was composed of two fragments, the first acquired from a certain Juan de Tro y Ortolano in Madrid in 1866, and the second from Juan de Palacios who tried to sell the smaller fragment in 1867.

It was said that part of the codex was bought in the Spanish province of Extremadura, the home of many of the conquistadors, including Hernan Cortes, who may have brought it to Spain.

In the same museum was the Tudela Codex, discovered by the Spanish ethnologist Jose Tudela de la Orden in 1940 and considered by many as one of the most significant pre-Columbian discoveries of the 20th century.

The codex dated from the mid-16th century and provided a glimpse into the religions, rituals, language and culture of the Aztecs.

The codex consisted of 125 pages, composed during the early days of the Spanish conquest, and consisted of three sections, written in Nahuatl and Spanish, the *Libro Indígena*, the *Libro Pintado Europeo*, and the *Libro Escrito Europeo*.

It had been lost and forgotten for centuries and was rediscovered by chance in 1940, in a private collection at La Coruña, in Northern Spain, subsequently presented to Jose Tudela, then deputy director of the Museo de America in Madrid.

The sun was going down as Simmo dreamily imagined himself in his Ibiza villa overlooking the Mediterranean, a fitting reward for half a lifetime in Belize. Without thinking he drifted towards the centre of the narrow road, as he glanced in the rear view mirror he saw the headlights of a fast approaching vehicle.

Before he knew it was on his tail and flashing its headlights, he pulled over, but the road was narrow, and as the vehicle, a large pickup,

passed, it sideswiped him sending his roadster into a violent skid. Simmo lost control, shot off the macadam into the dense jungle covered swamp that bordered the road where the roadster overturned and quickly sank, disappearing into the thick slime.

The pickup braked 70 metres or so further along the road and reversed, the driver shone the powerful spot light mounted above his door into the swamp, there was nothing to be seen, just a few bubbles as the dark green slime settled back into place.

Two men got out, they shouted in Spanish, one swore loudly in Russian, after a couple of minutes they got back into the pickup and disappeared into the night.

It wasn't until several days later Maria, Simmonds' worried secretary, contacted the police to inform them of his disappearance. It was nothing unusual in Belize, people came and went, perhaps he had gone to Ambergris or abroad as he often did, perhaps he had been the victim of a crime.

Maria went out to Simmo's place. His housekeeper knew nothing. He had said something about visiting the ruins, which ones she wasn't sure.

A week passed, then two, there was still no news, Simmo had disappeared off the face of the earth, without a trace, soon to be forgotten, unmourned...but not by all.

Vishnevsky had thought he knew everything in the offshore and money laundering rule book, perhaps he did, in Russia's tightly controlled opaque system, where justice was violent and expeditive, and where it was not easy to hide. But he was an amateur compared to those who had grown up in Caribbean offshore banking. Wallace and his likes knew every trick in the book as far as structuring financial schemes designed to hide money, where it came from, where it went, and above all the identities of its owners and the beneficiaries of the transactions.

Wallace's system could be broken down into three phases. Firstly, channelling the profits skimmed off commodities exported from Russia, for example, a cargo of nickel, aluminium, platinum, copper or phosphates is sold to fictive offshore company A at below market prices. Secondly, company A sells the commodities now on the high seas to company B, which sells them to a bona fide buyer at near market price. Thirdly the margin siphoned off in the process by company B is used to pay fictive commissions or buy fictive services from company C, which then proceeds to hide the profits behind a cascade of offshore shell companies before they are invested in real estate development, such as the Ambergris Golf Resort, or other solid assets, which can subsequently be placed on the international market and legally acquired by a US, UK or Europe investor, with the proceeds of the sale recycled into the legal economy through the regulated banking system.

Wallace and Simmonds were the essential cogs in the machine, Wallace the launderer oversaw the movement of funds, Simmonds provided of the legal services related to setting up the various elements of the conduit, mainly shell companies, holding companies, and offshore bank accounts.

CHAPTER 13

SIMMO HAD DISAPPEARED, EVAPORATED, it was not unusual in Belize where tropical swamps and shark infested waters abounded. It was not, however, the case of Igor Vishnevsky, his body, identified by a hotel room card found in a back pocket, had been found floating near the beach at the Coral Cove Resort on Ambergris Caye, and according to the autopsy had been exsanguinated—drained of all its blood.

All that was left of the Russian's legs were a few shreds of flesh and shattered bone, a shark attack, concluded the police report, which didn't explain the life jacket and what was left of a nylon rope knotted to it.

The Russian was suspected as having been part of a conduit that managed investments for highly placed Russian officials, buying and selling property, and channelling the profits to a Cayman Islands holding company that invested it in UK prime property.

Vishnevsky, according to the Mexican police, was resident in Cancun, where he had arrived some eighteen months earlier, travelling on a Cypriot 'golden' passport.

The Russian according to the police also held a Dominica passport under the Caribbean Citizenship by Investment (CBI) programme, which had set him back 100,000 dollars.

However, the Cypriot passport was much more interesting, allowing holders the right to live, work and travel freely in all countries of the EU as well as travel visa free to 176 other countries, including most countries of the Caribbean and South America, but required a much greater investment—two million euros in business or real estate.

Vishnevsky was one of several thousand non-EU citizens who had bought a Cypriot passport under the scheme, they were mainly

Russians, but also Ukrainians, Chinese and Middle Easterners, all of whom had one thing in common—their wealth.

Theoretically they had clean criminal records, but that was difficult to ascertain given the means a small country like Cyprus had to investigate declarations, so apart from a summary check on the Europol data base, the rejection rate was almost negligible.

Amongst those who successfully applied for a Cypriot passport was Jho Low, the previous owner of Pat Kennedy's mega yacht. Low had been behind the enormous financial scandal that ended up with the former

Malaysian Prime Minister Najib Razak in prison and billions of dollars missing from his country's sovereign wealth funds.

Others included well-known Russian oligarchs like Oleg Deripaska—owner of one of Russia's largest industrial groups, or more shady businessmen like Ali Beglov who was sentenced to two years imprisonment in 1990 for racketeering and extortion in Saint Petersburg. Ali then entered the oil bunkering business and became the local representative of Lukoil, one of Russia's largest oil and gas corporations, and by the end of the decade he had become general manager of the Lukoil's bunkering business which managed oil storage units in ports across Russia and abroad. In 2015, his business interests had expended into dairy products and his customers included Russia's Constitutional Court, the FSB, the State Duma, and the Federation Council.

Even more interesting was Mykola Zlochevsky, now living in Monaco, a former Ukrainian minister of ecology and natural resources, who also held a Cypriot passport. He had been accused of favouring his energy company, Burisma Holdings, which though based in Kyiv was registered in Cyprus. Burisma came to the attention of the US public after it emerged Joe Biden's son, Hunter Biden, had been on its board of directors whilst his father was in charge of American policy in the Ukraine.

Vishnevsky's mistake was to encourage top Russian government officials to invest in the luxury condominium and golf complex at Ambergris—near to the border with the Mexican Yucatan, which led to questions being raised by the opposition, led by Alexei Navalny, as to how they, not so richly paid officials could invest large sums of money in such valuable assets.

Vishnevsky was liquidated after the collapse of his real estate deals threatened to expose Sedov and VTB—known in banking and diplomatic circles as the Kremlin's bank, as being implicated in money laundering and the illegal transfer of funds via Cyprus and Belize, linked to subversive FSB, SVR and GRU operations—ranging across the geopolitical board— from London to Caracas, creating an embarrassing scandal at a moment when the opposition to Putin was on the rise.

Wallace, through Demitriev and then Vishnevsky, had discovered an endless source of what seemed like easy money, which he moved through a complex web of companies and bank accounts that little by little escaped the control of Vishnevsky, who was leading a high life in Cancun entertaining a flow of highly placed Russian official discovering the Yucatan's exotic pleasures—beaches, golf, cruises and the wonders of the Mayan civilisation. A breath of fresh air after the deprivations of Venezuela, now reminiscent of the USSR under Gorbachev and the economic collapse which Yeltsin had presided over. Wallace had persuaded the Russian everything was in order, it was the way things were done locally. And it was, business boomed, the tourist industry knew no limits, investors fought to buy land and build tourist resorts.

Who could have imagined the pandemic, a scenario from a Stephen King novel, the streets of Cancun silent, the usually packed shopping

centres fell silent, the beaches emptied, and the Ambergris development went belly-up.

Wallace's had not only invested the Russian's money in local real estate, but also in Cancun, the Dominican Republic and Jamaica, all of which were enmeshed in local corruption as cash flowed freely, driving up land prices with buyers fighting over sites as greedy politicians scrambled to get their snouts in the trough.

Dirty money was laundered as funds were shunted between accounts owned by obscure shell companies registered in Belize, Panama, the British Virgin Islands, Cyprus and other offshore tax haven, all of which enabled corrupt politicians and businessmen to hide massive sums of money from their governments.

Wallace, thanks to the companies Simmo set-up, had built a well oiled investment scheme on behalf of Vishnevsky's Russian friends with companies registered in offshore jurisdictions that ploughed cash into real estate developments he targeted. In that way the money was not only laundered, it avoided taxation and hid the identities of the ultimate beneficiaries hidden an opaque screen.

The trouble was Vishnevsky had become careless, too trusting, but above all, he like everyone else could have never imagined a pandemic, it was not in his or even the FSB's gamebook.

Simmo had turned a blind eye to the true nature of Wallace's business and as a result paid the price. In a way he had been luckier than the hapless Igor Vishnevsky, who had ended up as shark bait, towed behind an outboard off the Belize Barrier Reef, the waves sown with bloodied pigs guts, guaranteed to attract the Bull Sharks lurking off the reef.

Though the Belize police did not go into details, it was technique known to them, a punishment for cheats and double-dealers, invented by the pirates and drug runners that plagued the frontier zone between Belize and the Mexican state of Quintana Roo.

‘Can’t blame them,’ confided the Police Commissioner when he reported the Russian’s death to the Chief Justice, ‘Vishnevsky must have tasted as rotten as his reputation...those sharks usually leave nothing.’

CHAPTER 14

‘WELL ANNA, WHAT’S YOUR CONCLUSION,’ asked Pat

‘I have no doubt it’s a mix between a herbarium and a pharmacopoeia, the illustrations were drawn from living or dried plants. As far as the texts go, they describe applications to human illnesses. In short it’s an Aztec compendium of plants and their medicinal use.’

‘Medicinal?’

‘Yes, a pharmacopoeia contains instructions for the identification of medicines derived from animals, minerals and in this case plants, of which there are hundreds in the codex, it’s a truly remarkable document.’

Pat listened attentively.

‘For example there’s a remedy for constipation, another for what I believe is glaucoma, and there’s even one for long life.’

Pat was suddenly very attentive, his thoughts switched to Lifegen, his company at Sophia Antipolis, a science pole, situated in Provence between Nice and Cannes.

Lifegen was a scientific facility specialised in research into longevity and life extension, subjects dear to Pat’s heart.

She explained Aztec civilisation had been highly developed and even though ferrous metallurgy was unknown to them, their sophisticated system of medicine, based on plants and herbs, was extraordinarily advanced as witnessed by other surviving documents dating from before and immediately after the Conquest.

Anna recounted how the *Libellus de Medicinalibus Indorum Herbis*, written in 1552 by Martin de la Cruz, a Christianised Aztec, was one of

the best known texts. Friar Bernardino de Sahagun's treatise on Aztec daily life also contained a book with a large section devoted to medicinal herbs.

In addition was the *Rerum Medicarum Novae Hispaniae Thesaurus* composed by Francisco Hernandez de Toledo, a physician who in 1570 took part in the first scientific expedition to the New World, which undertook the study of its medicinal plants and animals, his work described more than 3,000 Mexican plants.

'So you see all of these codices contained botanical descriptions of the plants in Mexico and how the Aztecs used them, and for what ailments,' Anna concluded.

Pat nodded, it was if he already knew.

'There's one thing that's puzzling me,' Anna said.

'Fire ahead Anna.'

'How does all of this interest Lifegen?'

Pat looked a little uneasy, as though he was taking a decision.

'This is strictly confidential Anna,' he said softly. 'You know Lifegen was founded as a research centre for gerontology, well it's a little more than that. We have an objective, which we believe is realistic.'

She looked at him concentrating her thoughts, she knew Pat Kennedy well, he was no ordinary man and he was about to reveal something she suspected he had been hiding for some time.

'We have called it the Gilgamesh Project.'

'Gilgamesh? You mean the epic?' asked Anna unbelievably.

'Yes,' replied Pat a little crestfallen by her reaction.

*

Anna like any archaeologist was familiar with the Epic of Gilgamesh, considered to be the first work of literature in human history, an epic poem, which recounted the story of Gilgamesh, the Great King of Uruk, who reigned sometime between 3000 and 2500BC in his city-state near the Euphrates.

The epic was discovered inscribed in cuneiform on the fragments of clay tablets dating soon after that time, though the most complete version was found by Sir Austen Henry Layard, an English archaeologist, in 1849, written on 12 tablets excavated in the ruins of the library of the 7th-century BC Assyrian king, Ashurbanipal, in Nineveh—the capital of his empire, near Mosul, the present day city in Iraq.

The epic tells how Gilgamesh was tormented by the fear of death after he realised that he, too, would die. He cries, ‘How can I rest, how can I be at peace? Despair is in my heart. What my brother is now, that shall I be when I am dead. Because I am afraid of death I will go as best I can to find Utnapishtim whom they call the Faraway, for he has entered the assembly of the gods.’

Gilgamesh sets out on a long journey to the underworld to find Utnapishtim and discover the secret of immortality, across the Land of Night and the Waters of Death. After many tumultuous adventures he arrives in the land of Dilmun, where he finally meets Utanapishtim, the sole survivor of the Great Flood, who had been granted immortality by the gods.

Utanapishtim recounts the story of how he was warned by the god Ea of the coming deluge, and following his command built an ark for the animals and his family.

He then tells Gilgamesh eternal life will be granted if the Great King can stay awake for the next six days, but Gilgamesh falls asleep at once.

Utanapishtim has mercy on him and tells him of a wondrous plant that grows under the sea, like a flower with thorns, which would make rejuvenate him. Gilgamesh plucks the plant by binding stones to his feet to allow him to walk on the bottom of the sea. With it he plans to use the flower to make the old men of the city of Uruk young again and then himself. Unfortunately, he leaves the plant on the shore of a lake while he bathes, there it is stolen by a serpent.

The story ends with Gilgamesh weeping after having failed to achieve immortality and is brought back to Uruk by the ferryman Urshanabi, where, like all mortals he finally dies.

Pat admitted the goal of Lifegen was to discover the mechanisms to reverse ageing, and if not immortality then great age, without the ravages and decay that had always been the scourge of human ageing.

‘You see Anna, Lifegen is engaged in biomedical research into new therapies that could cure and prevent the diseases and disabilities of ageing,’ Pat told her, trying a more positive tack, ‘new ways if repairing the damage that builds up in our bodies over time.

‘It is a scientific fact that ageing is caused by the damage to the cellular and molecular structures of our bodies, as we age microscopic dysfunctioning slowly and imperceptibly eats away at our bodies.

‘So, goal we have set at Lifegen is to develop new kinds of drugs; the kinds that will regenerate cells, and eliminate the causes of their dysfunctioning. Returning ageing tissues to health, restoring the body’s youthful vigour,’ he said, evidently pleased with his explanation.

‘Our objective is to develop regenerative therapeutics to achieve these objectives, biotechnologies that will make life better.’

Anna smiled and wondered for who.

